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IN BRIEF



SP president takes 'PDA Rath' to Raebareli

LUCKNOW
Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday boarded a specially designed 'PDA Rath' from Lucknow for a visit to Raebareli as part of the party's broader mobilisation outreach across U.P. » **Page 4**

OBC creamy layer policy: apex court reserves orders

NEW DELHI
The Supreme Court on Thursday reserved orders on a plea by the Centre seeking prospective operation of a March 11 ruling to re-assess OBC non-creamy layer status as per a 1993 Office Memorandum. » **Page 14**

Polls rigged, CEC should quit immediately: Rahul

Prime Minister and Union Home Minister 'at the top of this conspiracy', says the Opposition leader; Ministers 'will be investigated', CEC should turn an approver in the alleged 'vote chori' issue, he adds

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Elections in India are being rigged, and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, and Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar acted as “*deshdrohis* (traitors)” by destroying the country’s votes, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi alleged on Thursday while demanding the immediate resignation of the poll official.

Speaking at a press conference here, the Congress leader said the CEC should turn an approver in the alleged ‘vote chori’ issue, as that would be an “act of nationalism”. The press conference came a day after *The Indian Express* reported



Sharp attack: Rahul Gandhi addresses the media at the Congress headquarters in New Delhi on Thursday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

ed that two Election Commissioners had major differences with the CEC and they formally objected 14 times in 10 months to decisions made in the name of the poll body.

“If tomorrow the BJP sweeps the national election, India will not believe it. So now we are heading

to the point where public expression will not allow the BJP to get the type of majority they were getting,” Mr. Gandhi told *The Hindu* in response to a question on the Opposition’s option.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 14

CJP asks Kumar to quit, warns of nationwide stir

NEW DELHI
The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Thursday demanded the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and warned of a nationwide agitation if he does not step down within 48 hours. » **PAGE 15**

Five Left parties announce protest against CEC, SIR

NEW DELHI
Five Left parties have announced a week-long protest across the country from Saturday seeking the ouster of CEC Gyanesh Kumar and a halt to the SIR. » **PAGE 15**



Strong points: U.S. President Donald Trump with Chinese President Xi Jinping in the White House Oval Office on Thursday. AP

China, U.S. must steer clear of conflict: Xi

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

Beijing and Washington must peacefully manage their superpower rivalry, Chinese President Xi Jinping told his U.S. counterpart Donald Trump on Thursday as the American leader gave him a lavish welcome to the White House.

While Mr. Trump hailed their “truly great friendship” on a day of sweeping pomp and circumstance, Mr. Xi used his state visit to lay down China’s red lines

on AI, call for “prudence” on Taiwan, and seek an end to the Iran war.

In his opening remarks, Mr. Xi said the two countries must ensure there is “no conflict and no confrontation between us”. He also warned that the development of artificial intelligence should be “always under human control” – in contrast to Mr. Trump, who has repeatedly dismissed warnings that AI could threaten humanity itself.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 14

Sahil Wakode's parents begin hunger strike for fast-track probe

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Parents of Sahil Wakode, the IIT Bombay student whose death by suicide on September 18 has sparked protests, began a hunger strike on Thursday at Azad Maidan seeking action against their son’s “tormentors”. Ravindra Wakode and Sonali Wakode also demanded a fast-track probe and alleged caste-based harassment.

The parents said their son, a second-year BTech student, led a team of 50 students on AI and robotics. “You can ask anyone. They will tell you how good a human Sahil was. Do you think such a student can do this?” Mr. Ravindra said.

The institute has postponed the mid-semester examinations scheduled for September 26-27 to October 10-11, an official said.

(Those in distress can dial Tele MANAS helpline at 14416)

Riding the wave



Against the tide: Fishermen in Visakhapatnam brave strong winds and turbulent waters to venture into the sea on Thursday. The passage of a deep depression along the north Andhra Pradesh coast has brought heavy rains especially in the north coastal region. K.R. DEEPAK

Journalist Ravi Nair gets bail

Press Trust of India
AHMEDABAD

A sessions court in Gujarat’s Gandhinagar granted bail to journalist Ravi Nair on Thursday, a week after he was arrested over his non-appearance in connection with a criminal defamation case.

A court in Mansa on February 10 had sentenced Mr. Nair to one-year imprisonment in the defamation suit filed by Adani Enterprises over certain social media posts and articles attributed to him.

‘Enter at own risk’: churches to non-Christians as anti-conversion law takes effect in Chhattisgarh

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

“In accordance with church management rules, entry into the church for worship is restricted to Christians. Others who enter voluntarily do so at their own risk” – reads a noticeboard in Hindi outside the 116-year-old Sunderganj Mennonite Church in Dhamtari, Chhattisgarh.

A similar board outside the Church of God in the city states: “Worship here is exclusively for Christians; if you are not legally a Christian, you will be held personally responsible.”

It has been nearly a month since such boards have come up outside churches in the city. “They have been put up primarily as a precautionary measure to avoid action under the Chhattisgarh Freedom of Religion Act, 2026,” said Diamond Philus, general secretary of the Dhamtari District Christian Forum.

The law, which was notified in August, is aimed at curbing religious conver-



The noticeboard in Hindi put up outside the 116-year-old Sunderganj Mennonite Church in Chhattisgarh’s Dhamtari. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

sions, according to Ministers in the BJP government.

‘Draconian provisions’
Mr. Philus said the law mandates that anyone seeking to change their religion must inform the district administration 60 days in advance. Terming the law’s provisions “draconian”, he alleged that it leaves room for anyone to be framed under it.

The forum claimed that more than 1,000 people have submitted self-declaration forms at the District Collectorate stating that

they were attending religious meetings at churches or prayer halls “voluntarily and at their own risk”.

Mr. Philus shared a copy of the declaration form, which seeks details of the applicant and the church or prayer venue. It states that attendance is voluntary and based on personal faith and freedom of conscience. It requires the applicant to confirm that there has been no force, threat, undue influence, inducement, fraud or deception, and no known instance of such means being

used for conversion has come to their notice.

He said another reason for putting up the boards was disruption of prayer meetings by members of right-wing groups. He said he hoped the boards would make the environment secure for the Christian community.

Such disruptions, as well as disputes over the last rites of the deceased, have often been reported in Dhamtari and other parts of the State, he said.

“We are not restricting anyone, but if people want to come, they should come at their own risk,” he said.

Citing an instance after the notices were put up that reaffirmed the need for them, Mr. Philus said, “A meeting was called at the District Collectorate on September 15. The forum was not informed that right-wing groups would be present. When they said we should not allow people inside the church till they have converted, the government officials supported their stand.”

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INBRIEF



Jamia students protest over notices to women hostellers

Three women hostellers at Jamia Millia Islamia were allegedly served eviction notices after raising concerns over hostel food and living conditions, the All India Students' Association alleged. The university termed the allegation a "misrepresentation", saying the notices were based on hostel eligibility criteria. Student organisations protested on Thursday, demanding withdrawal of the notices and warning of intensified campus protests. The university said the students had failed to meet the prescribed 55% eligibility criteria.

Motilal Nehru College teachers suspend classes over assault

Teachers at Motilal Nehru College have suspended classes in protest against increasing instances of violence against teachers, including the alleged assault of a teacher during Delhi University Students' Union campaigning on September 16. The teachers suspended all teaching and academic activity on Wednesday and continued the protest on Thursday. The teachers cited incidents of assault, hooliganism, defacement of public property and trespassing by unidentified students/outsideers. A teacher on duty was reportedly assaulted by campaigners.

Child rights commission logs 38 POCSO cases since July

The Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights (DCPCR) has received 377 complaints, including 38 cases under the POCSO Act, since its reconstitution in July, with Right to Education (RTE) issues accounting for the highest number, it said on Thursday. Of the total complaints, 206 related to RTE, followed by 87 on juvenile justice, 38 POCSO cases, 17 missing children cases, 16 child labour cases and 13 related to health and nutrition. The panel also took suo motu cognisance of 56 cases. Most complaints were reported from north-west Delhi.

DDA orders safety audit of pre-2001 buildings in Delhi

Owners of high-rises, high-footfall structures to finish audit in 3 months; Sept. 6 accused fled after collapse instead of helping victims: police to HC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) on Thursday directed structural safety audits of all high-rise buildings, including malls, hospitals and educational institutions, that were constructed or sanctioned before March 21, 2001, to be completed within three months.

Even buildings sanctioned before the prescribed date but less than 15 metres high and attracting high footfall, including group housing societies, institutional buildings, hospitals and cinema halls, will also have to undergo the assessment within the stipulated period, the urban body said.

The move comes against the backdrop of the September 6 building collapse in Satya Niketan, which claimed the lives of seven persons, five of whom were students.

Satya Niketan case

The police have arrested six persons, including the owners of the collapsed building, in the case so far.

In a submission on September 21, the police told the Delhi High Court that the "accused persons failed to take adequate safety precautions during the construction/repair/modification/alteration work carried out in and around the building, which result-



Seven persons died in the Satya Niketan collapse. A DDA official said the audit has been ordered keeping seismic risks in mind. FILE PHOTO

ed in a situation endangering human life and ultimately caused deaths".

In their eight-page status report, the police held the accused prima facie guilty of fleeing the site after the building collapse instead of taking responsibility for the incident or helping those trapped under the debris.

The matter is listed for hearing on Friday before a Bench of Chief Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia.

'Can rope in officials'

In Thursday's order, the DDA stated, "Structural engineers empanelled with the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, government institutes and other government agencies can conduct structural safety audits for the owners."

The order was issued keeping in mind structural safety against earthquakes,

said a senior official.

According to the Centre's National Institute of Disaster Management, the national capital lies in Seismic Zone IV, a high-risk zone, where earthquakes of magnitude 5 occur frequently.

Corrective measures

The urban body said that after completing the audit, building owners must carry out retrofitting and corrective measures, adding that in case of non-compliance, action will be taken against them.

Aside from the Satya Niketan tragedy, there have been two other building collapse incidents in the city in the recent past.

Six persons died after a multi-storey structure collapsed in Saket's Said-ul-Ajab while another such incident was reported from Karawal Nagar, with no deaths reported.

2 Hindu College students allege sexual harassment; FIR registered, probe on

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

The Delhi police have registered an FIR after two women students of Hindu College alleged that a group of men harassed them and tried to pull them into a car in Mukherjee Nagar around 9.30 p.m. on Wednesday. The incident occurred two days after the alleged gang rape at Astha Kunj Park.

The car owner has been traced, DCP (North West) Akanksha Yadav said, adding that efforts are under way to nab the accused.

One of the women students subsequently posted a video on Instagram recounting the incident. The woman said she and her friend were walking when a group of men in a white SUV approached them and passed lewd remarks.

Followed in car

When the students objected and asked the men to leave, the men allegedly abused them and continued following them in the vehicle. A few minutes later, when she tried to record the incident on her phone, the men allegedly came closer and tried to pull them into the vehicle.

The men fled when they saw her friend take out her phone to record the incident. The student also alleged that she and her friends initially approached Maurice Nagar police station to report the incident but were told that the spot fell outside its jurisdiction. In the video, the woman claimed that it took them between four and five hours and visits to three police stations, including the one in Maurice Nagar, before the FIR was registered.

One of the women has claimed that it took them 4-5 hours and visits to 3 police stations before the FIR was registered

The police said a written complaint regarding the incident was received on the intervening night of Wednesday and Thursday. The FIR was registered at the Mukherjee Nagar police station under Sections 78 (stalking), 79 (insulting the modesty) and 3(5) (common intention) of the BNS, and a probe into the incident is on, they added.

The incident comes amid heightened concerns over the safety of women students in Delhi.

On the night of the Mukherjee Nagar incident, a WhatsApp group of Lady Shri Ram College (LSR) students received a message from a student that a man had behaved indecently in front of her near National Park, close to the college's rear gate.

Response from DU

When reached for comment, DU Proctor Manoj Kumar Singh said the police were looking into the Mukherjee Nagar incident and the university was cooperating with them.

Regarding National Park, he said as of Thursday night, the LSR administration had not received any complaint.

"I took a round of the college today and the police in the area are increasing patrolling. They are working to light up the dark patches around the college. In case of any untoward incident, necessary action will be taken," said the Proctor.

Kalkaji gang rape accused sent to judicial custody

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Thursday remanded the three accused – Asif and brothers Hemant and Mukesh – arrested in connection with the alleged gang rape of a 17-year-old girl in Kalkaji in judicial custody for 14 days.

According to the FIR, the three posed as police personnel in Astha Kunj Park in south-east Delhi, where the girl had come with a friend, on the night of September 21, gang-raped her and beat up her friend.

The three were arrested on September 22. A city court remanded them in two-day judicial custody on Wednesday. The Delhi police have not sought their custody so far.

Phones sent to FSL

The mobile phones of all three accused have been sent to the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) for examination, Deputy Commissioner of Police (South East) Vineet Kumar said on Thursday.

Another officer said the three were frequently seen loitering in the park and that Mr. Asif was allegedly seen carrying weapons, including a knife and a firearm, and harassing young people.

The trio had repeatedly harassed women, although no formal complaint had been lodged against them in those instances, the officer added.

Mr. Hemant had allegedly been removed from a gym about a month ago after its management received multiple complaints from women about his improper behaviour, said the officer.

Apex court restricts stay of Allahabad HC order against Gautam Buddha Nagar DM to strictures

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has restricted its September 23 interim order staying Allahabad High Court's strictures and award of costs against Gautam Buddha Nagar District Magistrate Medha Roopam in connection with the detention of Delhi University student Akriti Chaudhary under the National Security Act (NSA).

The earlier version of the order published on Wednesday had reportedly said the "court is of the opinion that till the matter is heard on merits, the operation of paragraphs nos. 27 to 33 of the judgment, including award of costs and strictures against the petitioner, shall remain stayed".

However, the current version states that the

An advocates' group issued an open letter to the Chief Justice of India alleging "out-of-turn listing" and "special assignment" of the case to a "particular Bench"

"court is of the opinion that till the matter is heard on merits, the operation of paragraphs nos. 27 to 33 of the judgment, including award of costs and strictures against the petitioner, shall remain stayed".

The phrase "operation of the judgment" is no more part of the judicial order.

The interim order was passed by a Bench of Justices Satish Chandra Sharma and N.K. Singh.

On Thursday, an advocates' group, Lawyers As-

sociation for Constitution, issued an open letter to the Chief Justice of India alleging "out-of-turn listing" and "special assignment" of the case to a "particular Bench".

'Wrong precedent'

"The matter is also significant as the petitioner, who is a public servant, also happens to be the daughter of the Chief Election Commissioner of India (Gyanesh Kumar). The out-of-turn listing of the case has received special treatment and tends to set a wrong precedent," the letter, circulated by Supreme Court advocate Subhash Chandran on instant messaging platform WhatsApp, stated.

The letter also highlighted the "muting of the video conferencing facility" dur-

ing the hearing of the case.

"Hearings in the court are public hearings. This is particularly facilitated by the video conferencing available to lawyers, journalists and litigants at large," it added.

The case deals with Ms. Chaudhary's detention under the NSA in connection with the Noida workers' protest in April this year.

The Allahabad High Court had quashed the detention and directed payment of a compensation of ₹5 lakh to the student, to be recovered from the salaries of Ms. Roopam and other officials involved.

Ms. Roopam had appealed to the Supreme Court.

An interim order was passed even as the top court is yet to hear her appeal on merits.

Hindu College Staff Association condemns notices to 3 members

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Hindu College Staff Association (HCSA) on Thursday condemned the college governing body's decision to issue show-cause notices to three staff members.

The notices come against the backdrop of a controversy over admissions under the extracurricular activities and sports categories. At a meeting in August, the association alleged excess admissions and accused the principal

of playing a dubious role in facilitating those.

The HCSA said three members, including its president Ratan Lal and secretary Shankar Kumar, were served show-cause notices even as they were "legitimately representing the collective and unanimous mandate of HCSA meetings".

Principal Anju Srivastava said the decision to issue the show-cause notices was taken in view of the "derogatory e-mail" sent by the staff members.

HC rejects anticipatory bail plea of YouTuber in SC/ST Act case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Thursday dismissed YouTuber Ajeet Bharti's anticipatory bail plea in a case over alleged caste-based remarks against Nagina MP Chandrashekhara Azad, saying prima facie a case under the SC/ST Act was made out against him.

The case relates to a video that Mr. Bharti allegedly uploaded on August 22. According to the FIR, the video had around

23,100 views when the case was registered and contained caste-based abuses, slurs and derogatory remarks aimed at the Lok Sabha member, who hails from a Scheduled Caste community.

The FIR adds that the YouTuber made derogatory remarks against Dr. B.R. Ambedkar and SC and Scheduled Tribe communities.

The court said it had watched the relevant portions of the video before deciding Mr. Bharti's plea.

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Sh. Gurudev Singh Yadav Advocate

Returning Officer

PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Akanksha Jain, Parent of Minerva Jain, a resident of K-31/25A, Model Town III, Delhi-110009, state that I have changed my daughter's name from Minerva Jain to Mitra Jain for all future purposes, vide affidavit dated 28 March 2026 before Notary Public, Ratan Lal Gupta (Reg. No. 42050).

I, NO. 4375672L Rank Hav Name K Delhi, r/o Punarnamel Village, P.O. & P.S. Mao, District Senapati, Manipur - 795150, have declared by affidavit sworn before Oath Commissioner at Senapati, Manipur on 23-09-2026, that my wife's name is erroneously recorded as 'S. Kasheni' in my Part II order, whereas her correct and true name is 'Saheni Kasheni' as per Aadhaar No. XXXXXXXX7523. Both names refer to one and the same person.

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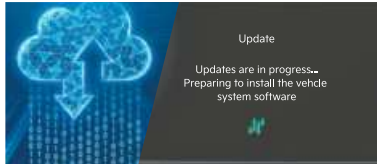


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A ND-NDE

INBRIEF



Court discharges Bhujbal in library contract bribery case

A court on Thursday discharged Maharashtra Minister Chhagan Bhujbal in an alleged bribery case linked to the award of a contract for a library at the University of Mumbai, saying criminal liability cannot be based on inference of “invisible support”. The court ruled that the prosecution had failed to demonstrate the “necessary nexus” between the Minister’s official acts and the alleged criminality. “The applicant’s position as PWD Minister (when offence was registered) explains his presence in the governmental process; it does not, by itself, establish his participation in a criminal conspiracy,” it said. PTI

Jailed gangster gets 12-hour parole to marry partner

Jailed gangster, Mainpal Dhilla, was released on 12-hour custody parole to marry his Cambodian partner, whom he had met in that country after he fled India using a fake identity before being extradited last year. Dhilla (50) was brought to a farmhouse in Jhajjar district on Thursday, where the ceremony will be held. The gangster will be marrying his Cambodian partner, Meta Chan, the police said. The gangster had met her when he fled to Cambodia while jumping parole in 2018. The couple then started living together and had children. Three of her children are accompanying her for the marriage. PTI

Akhilesh takes ‘PDA Rath’ to Raebareli, says oppressed people getting united in U.P.

Trip part of SP’s broader mobilisation outreach across the State focusing on its Backward, Dalit, and minority social coalition ahead of 2027 Assembly poll; party to have allies, says its president

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday boarded a specially designed ‘PDA Rath’ from Lucknow for a visit to Raebareli as part of the party’s broader mobilisation outreach across Uttar Pradesh focusing on its Backward, Dalit, and minority (Pichhda, Dalit, Alpsankhyak) social coalition ahead of the 2027 Assembly election.

Mr. Yadav is set to take this ‘PDA Rath’ all over the State in the run-up to the poll. The SP said its party president will visit places and meet people “facing atrocities at the hands of feudal forces backed by the BJP government”.

Speaking in Raebareli, Mr. Yadav urged people to support the SP and join the PDA movement. “The chariot is a symbol of Kurukshetra and Mahabharata in our country’s culture. Even God had once recited the Gita on a similar chariot. The fight against these



Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav greeting people during the party’s PDA Rath Yatra in Raebareli on Thursday. ANI

dominant, hegemonic people is not over yet. Through the PDA movement, all our oppressed and humiliated people are becoming united,” he said.

The SP president accused the BJP government of using the bulldozer on marginalised and innocent people. “These people who are roaming around with bulldozers, they do not use them on their own people; they occupy ponds, land, houses but no action is taken. I would like to tell my workers to work towards increasing 27,000 votes in every Assembly constituency for the 2027

election,” he said.

On a tie-up for the poll, Mr. Yadav said the SP will have an alliance and the basis for deciding seats will be winnability. “Whoever can win a seat should get that seat,” he said.

‘Fake Hindus’

The SP president said Backwards and Dalits have realised their strength. “These [the BJP] are the fake Hindus who demolished countless temples by running bulldozers on Kashi, the oldest place on earth. This time, the people of PDA have realised their strength and num-

CIC for publishing paper-wise UPSC marks of candidates

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Central Information Commission (CIC) has recommended reinstating the practice of publishing the detailed break-up of marks obtained by selected candidates in the Civil Services (Main) Examination after finding that the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) had no record of any formal decision behind discontinuing the practice from 2018.

The recommendation came amid contradictory positions of the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) and DoPT on custody of the detailed marks.

While the UPSC told the commission that after declaration of the final result it gives the detailed break-up of marks to the DoPT and the Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration (LBSNAA), the DoPT maintained that the detailed marks are generated and maintained solely by the UPSC.

The matter arose from an RTI application seeking comparative data of marks obtained by all selected candidates in each General Studies paper, optional subject paper and the Per-

The order came amid contradictory positions of the UPSC and DoPT on custody of detailed marks

sonality Test over 10 years, up to 2023. The applicant also sought information on how different optional subjects had fared in terms of marks. The applicant contended that while paper-wise marks of recommended candidates were publicly disclosed until CSE 2017, only aggregate marks were being made available from 2018 onwards, affecting aspirants’ ability to assess performance trends in different optional subjects.

‘No file noting’

The CIC noted that despite being given a final opportunity, the DoPT failed to produce any file noting, office memorandum, policy decision or other record substantiating the discontinuation of publication of the marks from 2018 onwards.

The commission observed that the detailed marks “should be disclosed” to ensure “transparency and fairness in the selection procedure”.

JD(U) fields Neeraj Kumar for Bihar Council polls despite stiff opposition within party ranks

Press Trust of India
PATNA

Janata Dal (United) [JD(U)] spokesman and third-term MLC Neeraj Kumar has been given the ticket for the upcoming Bihar Legislative Council polls, notwithstanding stiff opposition to his candidature from some quarters within the party.

The name of Mr. Kumar, a former State Minister, figured in the list of four candidates announced by the party for the October 23 elections.

He will seek a fourth consecutive term from the Patna Graduates constituency, which he has been representing since 2008.

However, this time, the pitch has been queered for the trusted lieutenant of former Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, also the JD(U) supremo, with party MLA Anant Kumar Singh vowing



Neeraj Kumar

to “work towards his defeat”.

Mr. Singh has been sore with Mr. Neeraj Kumar since 2015 when the former had contested from the Mokama Assembly seat as an Independent, and the latter was in the fray as a JD(U) candidate.

Besides Neeraj Kumar, the other three candidates are spokesman Abhishek Jha, Anand Pushkar and Ghanshyam Rai.

JSP names candidates
Meanwhile, the Jan Suraj Party (JSP) on Thursday an-

nounced candidates for three more of the eight Bihar Legislative Council seats, completing its list of nominees. The party, which had announced candidates for the other five seats on September 20, has fielded Anuj Singh from the Patna Graduates constituency, currently represented by JD(U) MLC Neeraj Kumar.

Other candidates named on Thursday by the party are Vimohan Kumar (Tirhut Graduates) and Bhushan Jha (Tirhut Teachers).

On September 20, the party announced names of five candidates, including MLC Afaq Ahmed, who would seek to retain the Saran Teachers seat that he won in 2022 with support of Mr. Kishor, who was then carrying out a public awareness campaign that culminated in the floating of the outfit.

Assam Cabinet approves rule that makes Muslim marriage registration compulsory

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

The Assam Cabinet headed by Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday approved a rule that makes the registration of Muslim marriages compulsory.

The Assam Muslim Marriage Registration (Compulsory) Rules, 2026, operationalise the registration framework under the Assam Compulsory Registration of Muslim Marriages and Divorces Act, 2024, which replaced a piece of legislation enacted in 1935

The colonial-era Assam Muslim Marriage and Divorce Registration Act provided for voluntary registration, although a 2010 amendment made registration compulsory.

The 2024 legislation followed the Assam government’s decision to repeal the 1935 law. It argued that the old framework was outdated and could allow registration of marriages in-



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma chairing a Cabinet meeting at Lok Sewa Bhawan in Guwahati on Thursday. ANI

volving minors. According to the new law, the woman must be at least 18 years old and the man 21 years old at the time of marriage.

The 2024 Act also shifted the registration process from licensed Muslim registrars or qazis to government registration officials.

The framework makes marriage registration a formal State process. Under the 2024 Act, applications require proof of identity, age and residence, along with declarations by the

couple. The law also provides for public notice and a 30-day objection period before registration.

‘Protection of rights’

The stated purpose of the 2024 legislation includes compulsory registration and protection of the rights of married Muslim women and men. It also sets conditions relating to legal age, free consent, and prohibited relationships.

The Chief Minister said the new rules are expected

to bring Muslim marriage registration under a more standardised government procedure, while creating a formal documentary record of marriages across the State.

Durga Puja bonus

The Cabinet also announced a special Durga Puja bonus for beneficiaries of the Arunodoi scheme, a social welfare initiative, under which money is transferred to the bank account of a nominated female member of each eligible household.

“Arunodoi beneficiaries will receive ₹1,500 in October instead of the regular monthly assistance of ₹1,250. The enhanced payment is being provided ahead of Durga Puja as a special festive-season benefit,” the Chief Minister said. The other decisions included providing subsidised sugar and dal at ₹100 in October instead of the earlier proposed price of ₹105.

Veeramani case: two IPS officers shunted out

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Two senior IPS officers who were at the helm of the Chennai Police Commissionerate when a complaint accusing Gem Granites owner Veeramani of indulging in predatory sexual behaviour targeting minor girls first surfaced were removed from their posts on Thursday.

Additional Chief Secretary (Home) K. Manivasan said in an order that A. Arun, ADGP, Tamil Nadu Police Academy, and N. Kannan, Commissioner of Police, Coimbatore, were being transferred with immediate effect and placed on compulsory wait.

The order did not specify reasons for their transfer.

DGP (Training) Rajeev Kumar will now hold the additional charge of the police academy.

Patient’s family alleges Rewa hospital blood bank refused donor from another caste; administration denies charge

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

The family of a girl admitted to a government-run medical college and hospital in Madhya Pradesh’s Rewa has alleged that the blood bank staff refused to accept blood from an acquaintance belonging to the Brahmin community, asking them instead to arrange a donor from their own caste. The patient, who hails from Sidhi district, belongs to the Vaishya community.

The alleged incident took place on Tuesday at Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital under the Shyam Shah Medical College in Rewa. The hospital administration, however, denied the charges, stating that two potential donors brought by the family had



The hospital administration claimed that two potential donors were rejected due to their medical conditions. FILE PHOTO

been rejected due to their medical conditions.

Bajinath Vaishya, uncle of the patient, said he had called a friend of his, Jitendra Pandey, to donate blood after doctors refused to take blood from a family member who is under 17 years. “When we took him to the blood bank, the doctor asked him where he

had come from and said, ‘You are a Pandey and she [the patient] is a Vaishya. It won’t work.’ He asked us to bring a relative or someone from our own caste or get a written permission from our doctor,” he said.

Mr. Bajinath alleged that the doctor treating his niece had earlier said they could give blood of any



This is a very serious matter that has come to my attention. The blood bank is the only place where caste or religion is never asked. This allegation is completely false

DR. LOKESH TRIPATHI
Blood bank in-charge at Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital

group to the blood bank and get the matching blood for the patient. “But when we went to him again, he asked us to arrange matching blood. Now, they are also not letting us through the gate,” he told reporters outside the hospital.

Virendra Singh Vaishya, another relative, said the girl was brought to the hos-

pital in critical condition and needed urgent blood transfusion. “They are refusing to take his [Mr. Pandey’s] blood. I have to undergo an operation soon, so I am not allowed to donate blood]. Where should we go now and find more people?” he said.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, hospital superintendent Dr. Priyank Sharma rejected the allegations and said an inquiry has been conducted into the matter.

Dr. Lokesh Tripathi, blood bank in-charge who conducted the inquiry, said caste is never brought up at a blood bank.

“This is a very serious matter that has come to my attention. The blood bank is the only place where caste or religion is never asked. This allegation is completely false,” he said.

Press Trust of India
SRINAGAR

A local court in Jammu and Kashmir’s Shopian district on Thursday ordered the reopening of Darul Uloom Jamia Siraj-ul-Uloom, an educational institution declared an unlawful entity under the anti-terror law Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) earlier this year by the administration.

The court of Principal and Session Judge Shopian, Mehmood Ahmad Chowdhary, directed that until the matter is fully adjudicated, the institute be permitted to reopen and resume educational activities.

Speaking to reporters, Advocate S.M. Iqbal, who represents the institute, said that while the interim

The judge observed that govt.’s material at this prima facie stage is not sufficient to justify keeping the institution closed

relief has been granted, the main case is still ongoing.

“The main trial is still underway, but we filed an interim application because the future and education of children were at stake. Around 1,200 students were studying at Siraj-ul-Uloom, out of whom approximately 400 were residential boarders as this is a boarding and lodging institution,” Mr. Iqbal said.

He said the institute submitted that properties were deteriorating and the government had not made

proper administrative arrangements.

Until witnesses are examined and the trial concludes that unlawful activity was going on at Siraj-ul-Uloom, the institute should not remain locked, he said. “It will take time to prove that everything complies fully with the Constitution of India and no unlawful acts were committed,” Mr. Iqbal noted.

‘Excessive power used’

The advocate said that the judge observed that the government’s material at this prima facie stage is not sufficient to justify keeping the entire institution completely shut. “The court found that excessive power had been exercised relative to the allegations made,” he added.

R.G. Kar
probe: CBI
submits
report to HC

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

The Central Bureau of Investigation on Thursday submitted a report to the Calcutta High Court on its probe into an alleged conspiracy in the rape and murder of an on-duty doctor at the West Bengal government-run R.G. Kar Medical College and Hospital here in August 2024.

A Division Bench, comprising Justices Shampa Sarkar and Tirthankar Ghosh, directed that the matter will be taken up for arguments again on November 20.

The Division Bench had on August 28 directed the CBI to submit a report to it, indicating the path through which the probe agency has been able to locate the involvement of certain persons in its investigation into the alleged conspiracy in the rape and murder of the medic at the hospital in north Kolkata.

Row in Punjab over ED raids in money laundering case

BJP ‘weaponising’ Central agencies to intimidate opponents ahead of Assembly poll, alleges AAP as its party workers stage a protest outside GMADA office in Mohali; raids expose AAP: Akali Dal

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Even as the Enforcement Directorate continued to conduct survey and search operations at offices of the Greater Mohali Area Development Authority (GMADA) in Punjab’s Mohali and premises linked to senior Housing and Urban Development officials in connection with an alleged money laundering probe, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Thursday blamed the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) for “weaponising” Central agencies to intimidate opponents ahead of upcoming Assembly election.

AAP workers staged a protest outside the office of GMADA in Mohali on Thursday where the ED was conducting its search operation as part of its in-



ED action had disrupted government work for three days, said Harpal Singh Cheema.

vestigation, which began on Tuesday. The ED also searched the residence of the nephew of Punjab Cabinet Minister Hardeep Singh Mundian in Sahnewal in Ludhiana on Wednesday.

‘Poll through fear’
Mr. Mundian, addressing a press conference here, said, “The BJP is trying to fight the election through fear after failing to generate public enthusiasm at its ral-

lies. Punjab is not a place where people can be intimidated,” he said.

Senior AAP leader and Cabinet Minister Harpal Singh Cheema said the ED action had disrupted government work across Punjab for three days, causing inconvenience to people while the searches had yielded nothing. “The Central government’s use of ED, Income Tax Department and Election Commission against Opposition-ruled States had become its trademark, but Punjab would not be intimidated and the Punjabis would give the BJP a democratic reply,” he said.

Mr. Cheema said the conduct of officials during searches had also raised serious concerns. “During a raid at the house of a relative of an AAP Minister, ED officers tried to intimidate children and elderly family

members. Is this the manner in which a Central investigating agency is supposed to function?” he said.

‘Facts, records’
Hitting back, Punjab BJP president Kewal Singh Dhillon said, “The AAP government should address the issues under investigation through facts and records rather than political allegations.”

The Shiromani Akali Dal also took a shot at AAP. Senior Akali leader Daljit Cheema said the ED raids have “exposed the real face of AAP”. He said it was surprising that AAP was going into overdrive over the raids. “If any officer has done any wrong, the party should support the ED action and ask for details of the corruption in order to take action against the guilty officers.”

Haryana plans ‘Parali Protection Force’ to check stubble burning

Press Trust of India
CHANDIGARH

Haryana will deploy a ‘Parali Protection Force’ comprising police personnel, Agriculture Department officials and administrative officers at the district and block levels to prevent paddy stubble burning, officials said on Thursday.

The State will also intensify late-evening patrolling and use drones to monitor farm fires, while providing farmers an incentive of ₹1,200 per acre for optimal utilisation of crop-residue management machinery.

The steps are part of Haryana’s action plan to eliminate stubble burning ahead of the paddy harvesting season, with procurement set to begin soon.

Stubble burning in Punjab and Haryana is often blamed for the rise in air pollution in Delhi-NCR. With a short window between the paddy harvest in October-November and sowing of the Rabi crop,



Haryana will also intensify late-evening patrolling and use drones to monitor farm fires. FILE PHOTO

particularly wheat, many farmers burn crop residue or ‘parali’ to quickly clear their fields.

Chief Secretary Anurag Rastogi on Thursday reviewed the State’s action plan for elimination of stubble burning and compliance with directions of the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM).

The enforcement plan stipulates three actions in every verified case of paddy stubble burning – registration of an FIR, challan and a “red entry” in the farmer’s land record. Envi-

ronmental compensation charges will also be imposed and recovered from violators, an official statement said.

At the same time, the government is focusing on incentives and machinery availability to provide farmers alternatives to burning. The State is providing a subsidy on the purchase of crop-residue management machines, for their optimal utilisation. The government plans to move balers, rakers and other machines between districts according to paddy harvesting schedules.

Jailed Congress Nandigram byelection candidate’s wife seeks Oppn.’s support

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Arpita Pradhan, wife of Congress’s Nandigram by-poll candidate Milan Pradhan, appealed to all Opposition parties on Thursday to support her jailed husband. She said she would start campaigning for him on Friday.

Mr. Milan, who was arrested for his alleged involvement in cases related to

rioting, murder and criminal intimidation that were filed during the 2007 anti-land acquisition movement in Nandigram, is unable to campaign as he has been remanded in judicial custody till October 7.

The bypoll in Nandigram is scheduled for October 6, with campaigning ending on October 4.

“We want everybody to be here. Not just [Tritanmool Congress leader] Ma-

mata Banerjee, all Opposition parties should come together to support him. If needed, the CPI(M) can also join,” Ms. Arpita told mediapersons after attending a Congress press conference in Kolkata.

Justice Saugata Bhattacharya of the Calcutta High Court on Thursday verbally asked Additional Advocate General Rajdeep Majumdar to allow Mr. Pradhan to contest the bypoll.

Uddhav seeks special House session to discuss steps taken to tackle dry spell

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

With several parts of Maharashtra reeling under a dry spell, Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray on Thursday demanded that the State government hold a special session of the legislature to discuss the steps taken in view of the looming threat of drought.

Addressing a press conference here, he said the

State government should hold Cabinet meetings separately in Western Maharashtra, especially in Solapur which is one of the worst-hit districts, Vidarbha and Chhattrapati Sambhajinagar in Marathwada.

‘Farm loan waiver’
The government should prepare a dashboard which will give district-wise and taluka-wise information on financial assis-

tance given to farmers, village-wise information of water tankers deployed, fodder shelter for farmers, Mr. Thackeray said, seeking a complete farm loan waiver. “The government should hold a special session, preferably next week and spell out the steps undertaken by it because the government has to fulfil the assurances given on the floor of the House,” he said.

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Yet to assess impact of mines Act on Odisha, says Minister as legislators flag potential loss

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR



Steel and Mines Minister Bibhuti Bhusan Jena

many as 13 questions.

Replying to the questions, Steel and Mines Minister Bibhuti Bhusan Jena said the State government has not yet conducted a quantified assessment of the impact of Section 9D on the State’s revenue.

“No specific estimate of financial gain or loss has been made at this stage regarding the amended provisions,” the Minister said, adding that the State government will assess the financial impact after the Central government formulates the necessary rules and regulations.

Opposition parties also stated that Odisha’s Advocate General, while arguing for the State in the Supreme Court, had justified imposing a levy on mineral-bearing lands. To this, the Minister said the figures and positions referred to as having been published in the *Odisha Review*, a government publication, or placed before the Supreme Court were not being treated as departmental assessment for the purpose of quantifying the present financial impact of Section 9D.

“Any such comparison would be made only after the legal and operational implications of the amended provision are fully ascertained,” he said.

The Minister’s reply comes even as Chief Minister Mohan Majhi and former Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan had earlier dismissed concerns about possible loss to

the State exchequer due to the recent amendments.

Call for protests
Meanwhile, the BJD and the INDIA bloc parties have called for protests in front of the Assembly on September 28 and 29 respectively alleging that the State stands to lose over ₹1 lakh crore in tax arrears and ₹12,000 crore in annual revenue as per the provisions of the amended Act.

The BJD said party president Naveen Patnaik would lead its rally to demand repealing of the Act. “Since Odisha possesses 44% of the total mineral resources available in the country, the State will suffer the maximum loss,” the party stated, adding that it was unfortunate that State BJP leaders have been arguing that Odisha will benefit rather than suffer losses. The BJD said the protest would be expanded to the entire State.

Timings			
DELHI			
FRIDAY, SEP. 25			
RISE	06:11	SET	18:14
RISE	17:24	SET	04:37
SATURDAY, SEP. 26			
RISE	06:11	SET	18:13
RISE	17:54	SET	05:36
SUNDAY, SEP. 27			
RISE	06:12	SET	18:12
RISE	18:25	SET	06:36
Delhi Weather			
Delhi City	max	min	
Safdarjang	36	26	
Palam	36	26	
	34	24	

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Ref: NIRM/ESTT/RMT/CANC-01/2026 25.09.2026
CANCELLATION NOTICE & FEE REFUND
Direct recruitment of 07 Group 'A' Posts of Scientist-I (Pay Level-10) initiated vide ADVT/01/2025-26 dtd 04/08/2025 stands CANCELLED due to admin exigencies. Applications received are treated as null & void.
Non-SC/ST applicants must visit <https://job.nirm.in> before 29.09.2026 to securely submit their bank details for full fee refund of ₹1,000/-.
Inconvenience regretted. Controller, NIRM

 DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER
Delhi Transco Ltd, a Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking, invites online tender for the following work :
Tender No. T26P750004: New Construction/ Modification of existing foundations for 500 MVA Tr. Along with auxiliary equipment foundation, firewall, trench, various other foundation, soak pit and connection with sump well, NIPFES, NCT, etc including demolition and dismantling work.
For complete details of the tender please visit following websites :-
<https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> (Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_296534_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique No. DTL-0175-220926.
Last date for bid submission:- 28.10.2026, 13:00 Hrs.
All Corrigendum/Addendum/ Amendments/Date of Extension/ Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.

राजिस्ट्री सं. डी.एन.-33004/99 REGD. NO. D.L.-33004/99


भारत का राजपत्र
The Gazette of India
सी.जी.-आर.जे.-अ.-21092026-276334
CG-RJ-E-21092026-276334
असाधारण
EXTRAORDINARY
भाग II - खण्ड 3 - उप-खण्ड (ii)
PART II - Section 3 - Sub-section (ii)
प्राधिकार से प्रकाशित
PUBLISHED BY AUTHORITY
सं. 4883] नई दिल्ली, मंगलवार, सितम्बर 15, 2026/चाद 24, 1948
No. 4883] NEW DELHI, TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 15, 2026/BHADRA 24, 1948

MINISTRY OF RAILWAYS
(West Central Railway)
NOTIFICATION
Kota, the 15th September, 2026
S.O. 5074(E).—In exercise of the powers conferred by sub-section(I) of section 20A of the Railways Act, 1989 (24 of 1989) (hereinafter referred to as the said Act), the Central Government after being satisfied that for the public purpose, the land, the brief description of which is given in the schedule annexed hereto, is required for the purpose of execution, Kota—Mathura section in Mathura District Construction of Road Over Bridge on LC No. 260 In District Mathura in the State of Uttar Pradesh hereby declares its intention to acquire such land:
Any person interested in the said land may within a period of thirty days from the date of publication of this notification in the Official Gazette, raise objection to the acquisition and use of such land for the aforesaid purpose under sub-section(I) of section 20D of the said Act:
Every such objection shall be made to the competent authority, namely Special land acquisition officer Mathura. Uttar Pradesh in writing and shall set out the grounds thereof on the competent authority shall give the objector an opportunity of being heard, either in person or by legal practitioner and may after hearing all such objections and after making such further enquiry, if any as the competent authority thinks necessary by order either allow or disallow the objections.
Any order made by the competent authority under sub-section (2) of Section 20D of the said Act shall be final.
The land plans and other details of the land covered under this notification are available and can be inspected by the interested person at the aforesaid office of the competent authority.
SCHEDULE
Brief description of land to be acquired with or Construction work of Road Over Bridge at Level Crossing No. 260, Mathura District between Kota- Mathura Section in District in the state of Uttar Pradesh.

S. No.	Tehsil	Name of Village	Plot No.	Area propose for land Acquisition (In Hect.)
1	2	3	4	5
1			254 M.	0.2419
2			255	0.0544
3			261	0.2025
4			291	0.0578
5			292 M.	0.0089
6			295 M.	0.0608
7			296 M.	0.0041
8	Sadar	Uamri	297	0.0115
9			298	0.2542
10			299	0.0022
11			300	0.0409
12			341	0.0147
13			342	0.0412
14			343	0.2683
15			344 M.	0.0522
-	-	-	Total	1.3156
1			600	0.0066
2			601	0.1264
3			602	0.0039
4			605	0.0279
5			669	0.2547
6			670	0.0399
7	Govardhan	Kosi Khurd	673	0.0087
8			675	0.0026
9			676	0.0262
10			678	0.0881
11			679	0.0204
12			674	0.0021
13			683	0.0060
-	-	-	Total	0.6135
-	-	-	Grand Total	1.9291

[Computer No. 260401 File No. E-WCR-KOTA0BRGL(GCBBR)/6/2024-CERSW]
SAURABH MISRA, Chief Project Manager

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Himachal Pradesh
Jal Shakti Vibhag
NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER
Online bids on items rate basis are invited by the Executive Engineer, Jal Shakti Division Rajgarh on behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh, in electronic tendering system in two covers for the under mentioned work from the contractors/firms of appropriate class enlisted with Himachal Pradesh Jal Shakti Vibhag.

Sr. No	Description	E/ Cost	E/Money	Time	Cost of Form
1	Operation and Maintenance of various schemes under Jal Shakti Division Rajgarh Distt. Sirmour for Three/Two/One year (SH- 7 No. schemes for 3 year, 8 No schemes for 2 year and 8 No. schemes for one year)	5,61,50,448/-	636505/-	3 Year/ 2 Year/ 1 Year	10000/-

NOTE:- Class B Contractor Also Eligible for Participating of This tender as per approval granted to Higher office vide letter No. 5297-98 dated 22-09-2026
1. Tender documents and other instructions can be downloaded or viewed online from the portal <http://hptenders.gov.in> by the firms/individual registered on the website which is free of cost.
2. As the bids are to be submitted online are required to be encrypted and digitally signed, the bidders are advised to obtain Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) from suitable vendors or from any authorized agency at the earliest.
2. Key dates will be as under:-
1 Date of Online publication 22-09-2026 AT 5:00 PM
2 Downloading of e-tender Documents From 22-09-2026 at 5:00 PM up to 1:00 PM on 01-10-2026
3 Date of submission of e-tendering From 22-09-2026 at 5:00 PM up to 1:00 PM on 01-10-2026
4 Physical submission of earnest money deposit and cost of tender documents Up-to 1:00 PM on 01-10-2026
5 Date of opening of Cover-1 (Eligibility criteria) and Cover-2 (Technical bid) 01-10-2026 at 1:30 PM
6 Date of Opening of Financial Bids Shall be intimated separately. Cover-2
The Terms and Conditions may be read online in E-Procurement site.
HIM.SUCHANA AVAM JAN SAPARK.
Executive Engineer
Jal Shakti Division, Rajgarh
HP/3647/2026-2027

Govt. of Bihar
Department of Industries
DIRECTORATE OF MSME
2nd Floor, Vikas Bhawan, Bailey Road, Patna 800015
Tender Notice No:2269
Online vent short e-tender are invited by the Director MSME, Department of Industries, Govt. of Bihar, Patna for selection of event management agencies/ companies for MSME Event 2026 to be organized at Babu Sabhagar, near Gandhi Maidan, Bihar..

Sl. No.	Particulars	Details
1	Designation and address of the Department	Director (MSME), Department of Industries, Government of Bihar
2	Publishing Date	25.09.2026
3	Bid Submission Start Date and Time	25.09.2026, 12:00 PM
4	Bid Submission End Date and Time	29.09.2026, 10:00 PM
5	Technical Bid Opening Date and Time	30-09-2026, 12:00 PM
6	Financial Bid Opening	To be communicated later
7	Contact Details	Shri Ajay Kumar Dixit Assistant Director, Department of Industries Mobile - 9471675640 Email-dir-msme.ind-bih@gov.in
8	Mode of Proposal submission	Online through eproc2 Portal
9	RFP details can be found on	https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in
10	Bid Validity	90 days from the date of bid submission
11	Method of selection	QCBS (70:30)

Note:
1. Director MSME, Department of Industries, Patna, Bihar reserves the right to reject or cancel the tender or any part thereof without assigning any reasons.
2. The tender document can be obtained from the website of Department of Industries, Government of Bihar.
For any queries regarding tender please contact: Mobile-- 9471675640
Email-dir-msme.ind-bih@gov.in

Toll Free Number: 1800 572 6571
Email Id: eproc2support@bihar.gov.in
During 08:00 AM to 07:00 PM (All days in week except state holidays)
eProc 2.0 Help Desk Address:
RJ Complex, 2nd Floor, Opposite Vidyapeeth Institute, Khajpura, Ashiana Road, P.S. - Shastri Nagar, Patna 800 014, Bihar

Joint Director
MSME Directorate
Department of Industries
PR. No. 012625 (Industry) 2026-27
This information is available on website www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar also

सुरक्षित जीवन अपनाओ, अपनी नियमित एच.आई.वी. जाँच कराओ।



स्थान: गया जी, बिहार 2026
पितृपक्ष मेला
25 सितंबर से 10 अक्टूबर 2026 तक
" एक इन्फ्लुएंसर की नजर से "
कंटेंट क्रिएटर, ब्लॉगर, ट्रैवल इन्फ्लुएंसर, फोटोग्राफर • वीडियोग्राफर • रील मेकर
प्रविष्टि जमा करने की तिथि
25 सितंबर से 11 अक्टूबर शाम 5 बजे तक
पर्यटन विभाग, बिहार सरकार आपके लिए लेकर आया है सुनहरा अवसर
पितृपक्ष मेला 2026 में पिंडदान, तर्पण और श्राद्ध की आस्था को अपने कैमरे में कैद करें और अपनी रचनात्मकता के माध्यम से दुनिया तक पहुँचाएँ और जीते आकर्षक पुरस्कार ।
आकर्षक पुरस्कार
प्रथम पुरस्कार – ₹ 3,00,000
द्वितीय पुरस्कार – ₹ 2,00,000
तृतीय पुरस्कार – ₹ 1,00,000
चतुर्थ पुरस्कार – 2 प्रतिभागियों को ₹ 50,000 प्रति प्रतिभागी
प्रशंसा / सात्वना पुरस्कार – 5 प्रतिभागियों को ₹ 25,000 प्रति प्रतिभागी
कैसे भाग लें ?
1. मूल एवं मौलिक डिजिटल कंटेंट तैयार करें
पुनःपुनः एबम गयीनी, बिहार में होने वाले पितृपक्ष मेला के ऊपर कंटेंट बनाएँ और इस प्रतियोगिता में हिस्सा लें।
2. निर्धारित दिशा-निर्देशों के अनुसार अपनी प्रविष्टि भेजें।
3. विस्तृत नियम एवं शर्त तथा पंजीकरण के लिए पर्यटन विभाग की आधिकारिक वेबसाइट पर जायें ।
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INBRIEF



Police issue formal orders for SIT in CMRL payoffs case

The police in Keralam have issued formal orders appointing a Special Investigation Team (SIT) led by Crime Branch Superintendent of Police (SP) P. Vikraman to inquire into corruption allegations against Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena, former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas and his associates in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case. It will be supervised by the Additional Director General of Police (ADGP), Crime Branch.

Karnataka govt. announces one-time aid for farmers

The Karnataka government on Thursday announced a one-time relief of ₹2,500 to farmers across the State in view of crop losses due to drought conditions. The government also announced a moratorium of 12 months for loan repayment. All farm loans will get an extension between 36 months and 60 months, based on the tenure. The relief package is estimated to cost the exchequer ₹1,250 crore and will benefit about 45 lakh to 50 lakh farmers.

Telangana govt. forms panel to probe land irregularities

Telangana government has constituted a committee to inquire into alleged land irregularities in several villages across the State, including properties linked to BRS leaders K. Chandrasekhar Rao, K.T. Rama Rao, and T. Harish Rao. Commissioner of Collegiate and Technical Education A. Sridevasena has been appointed chairperson of the committee that has been tasked with examining violations of government rules in land listings.

‘There will be no shortage of *prasadam* at Sabarimala’

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB) has said that there will be no shortage of *aravana prasadam* during the Thulam month puja at Sabarimala and that adequate buffer stocks will be maintained ahead of the annual Mandalam-Makara-vilakku pilgrimage season. Addressing a press meet on Thursday, TDB president K. Jayakumar said the expansion of the *aravana* production plant was in its final stages and ruled out shortages in the future. The expansion would increase the plant’s daily production capacity from 2.6 lakh tins to 3.6 lakh tins. Dismissing reports that the Sabarimala gold crown had gone missing, Mr. Jayakumar said the 55-sovereign crown, donated by a devotee in 2012, was safely stored in the Samidhanam strong room. The Thiruvabharanam Commissioner had personally verified its presence, he said. He also clarified that the confusion arose after a similar item was moved to the strong room at Aranmula. Mr. Jayakumar said the board had invited tenders three times to procure jagery for *aravana* production as part of efforts to ensure transparency in raw material procurement. A sample supplied by a Pune-based company had passed inspection, and the Devaswom Vigilance Superintendent of Police (SP) would visit the company to assess its capabilities. A ‘tender-cum-e-auction’ system would also be introduced for allocating shops at Sabarimala to curb irregularities in the auction process.

Five killed in coastal A.P. districts as deep depression wreaks havoc

Harish Gilai
VISAKHAPATNAM

The deep depression over the Bay of Bengal, which crossed the north Andhra Pradesh coast close to Kalingapatnam during the intervening night of Wednesday and Thursday, has wreaked havoc across Uttarakhand, with five persons reportedly dying of electrocution in Anakapalli, Bapatla and Krishna districts. More than 50 trees were uprooted, electric poles were knocked down, multiple landslips occurred, road connectivity was cut off to many villages, and several colonies were inundated under the impact of heavy rain and gales.

DYFI targets Keralam CM over chartered flight to Malappuram

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

A ‘freebie’ row centred on Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan’s recent travel to flood-hit Malappuram district on a chartered flight lent by an “anonymous benefactor” appeared to dominate the political narrative in Keralam on Thursday. The Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) is organising painting competitions across the State, urging the public to use their “imagination” to conjure up the likeness of the “mysterious sponsor” whose identity Mr. Satheesan had refused to reveal. In a cynical jibe at the

T.N. claims Cauvery shortfall, Karnataka points to ‘drought’

Tamil Nadu says it is suffering from a deficit of 20,000 tmc ft of river water while Karnataka says it did its best to comply with water disbursement responsibilities; T.N. claims kharif crop affected

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday sought Karnataka’s response to a plea by Tamil Nadu that it is suffering from a shortfall of 20 thousand million cubic feet of Cauvery river water. Karnataka, in turn, submitted in the top court that it was facing a “terrible drought situation” and has complied, to the best, its responsibilities towards Tamil Nadu as an upper riparian State. Appearing before a Bench headed by Justice Vikram Nath, both State governments concurred on the point that the Cauvery water was a “very sen-



Both State governments concurred that Cauvery water was a ‘very sensitive’ issue. FILE PHOTO

sitive’ issue for them. “Karnataka is usurping all the water, depriving us of our own,” senior advocate C.S. Vaidyanathan submitted for Tamil Nadu. Senior advocate Shyam Divan, for Karnataka, said entire districts in the State have been declared as

drought-prone. “Yet, we have taken it on the chin and done our best to comply,” he submitted. The court gave Karnataka a week to file its response while scheduling the next hearing on October 12. Mr. Vaidyanathan, accompanied by senior ad-

Will appeal CWRC order: CM

CHITRADURGA The Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC) on Thursday recommended that Karnataka ensure a flow of 4,000 cusecs of water to Tamil Nadu for 15 days. “We will file an appeal...”, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said.

vocate G. Umapathy, complained that both the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC) and the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) have not addressed the deficit of Cauvery water due to Tamil Nadu from Karnataka.

SC rejects MLA’s plea over disqualification

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The Supreme Court on Thursday declined to grant any relief to Danam Nagender, whom the Telangana High Court recently disqualified as Member of Legislative Assembly under the anti-defection law. A Bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant, Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V. Mohana, said the High Court’s order did not re-

quire any interference. Senior counsel Mukul Rohatgi, appearing for Mr. Nagender, contended that there was a provision in the Tenth Schedule to condone the action of a member for giving up the party membership. The court noted that provision was applicable only when a member voted against the party whip. It cannot be applied when a legislator gives up membership of a party, the Bench noted.

21-year-old’s ‘suicide’ revealed as murder

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

What initially appeared to be ‘death by suicide’ of a 21-year-old engineering student in Telangana turned out to be a murder after the Peddpalli police found that she had allegedly been forced to consume pesticide and that a note was part of an attempt to make her death appear self-inflicted. The police arrested Na-

veen Kumar, a lecturer at the Singareni Collieries Polytechnic, on charges of murdering Thandra Akshitarani and attempting to stage her death. Ravi Kumar, a Singareni overman accused of threatening, blackmailing, and intimidating her in the name of love, was also arrested. Both were taken into custody on September 20. (For those in distress, counselling is available at Tele MANAS 14416.)



Several markets in Leh remained closed on Thursday to mark the first anniversary of the September 24, 2025 violence. ANI

Shutdown, prayers mark one year of Ladakh violence

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Special prayers were held and a shutdown was observed in parts of Ladakh on Thursday to mark the first death anniversary of four civilians who died in security forces’ firing on September 24 last year during an agitation over demands of Statehood and Sixth Schedule inclusion. Ladakh-based socio-politico-religious groups, including Leh Apex Body (LAB) and Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA), had called for a shutdown on the occasion. The shutdown call resulted in the closure of shops and business establishments in both Leh and Kargil districts. Traffic was also skeletal on the roads.

peace and remembrance”. Special prayers were held at the Nawang Dorjay Stobdan stadium for the four civilians, marking September 24 as ‘Martyrs’ Day’. LAB co-chairman Chering Dorjay Lakrook, KDA co-chairman Asgar Ali Karbalai, sitting Ladakh Member of Parliament Haji Hanifa Jan and activist Sonam Wangchuk addressed the gathering on the occasion. Speaking on the occasion, Mr. Wangchuk recalled how civilians peacefully demanding Statehood were “subjected to indiscriminate firing, without any firing order”. “Later, they were branded as anti-national and subjected to further oppression... We will fight for justice for the victims,” he said. Since Ladakh became a Union Territory in 2019, the Centre and local groups have held several rounds of talks over a special status under provisions of Article 371, following demands for Statehood and Sixth Schedule inclusion.

VB-G RAM G: Karnataka creates 1.56 crore person-days of work

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka has generated 1.56 crore person-days of employment under the Viksit Bharat - Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) scheme, as the State faces a severe drought situation, Rural Development and Panchayat Raj (RDPR) Minister Eshwar Khandre told the Legislative Assembly on Thursday. In a response during a special discussion on drought, BJP member V. Sunil Kumar raised concerns over the implementation of the employment scheme and said that preparations should have been made to utilise it on a large

Scheme should have been utilised on a larger scale in drought-affected areas, says BJP MLA

er scale in drought-affected areas. Mr. Khandre said that several works were being undertaken under the scheme, including the construction of farm ponds and check dams, dredging and rejuvenation of lakes, and measures aimed at improving groundwater levels. He said 318 works had been taken up under the scheme. According to the Minister, the government has allocated ₹2,900 crore for the current quarter for the

VB-G RAM G scheme, while ₹1,000 crore has already been released to districts as an advance. Mr. Khandre said the Union and the State governments were contributing ₹1,700 crore and ₹1,200 crore each towards the programme. He also said the State government was taking steps to ensure that people did not migrate in search of employment and was providing work locally. The Minister further said there had been complaints regarding the release of funds under the scheme and that the government was taking steps to address them. Mr. Kumar alleged that the State had given greater priority to the real estate sector than farmers.

Red sanders smuggler wanted in 99 cases held by A.P. police

A.D. Rangarajan
KADAPA

The Kadapa police in Andhra Pradesh reportedly nabbed Simpathi Jakeer alias Shaik Chempati Jakeer, a notorious red sanders smuggler with 99 cases against him, including 82 cases related to red sanders smuggling. Jakeer is reportedly known to have attacked the police as many as 80 times in the past, including attempting to stab officials with a knife, running them over with his vehicle or hurling large stones while trying to escape. Following intelligence inputs, the police intensified surveillance on the various smuggling routes ov-



SP Nachiket Vishwanath Shelke says red sanders smuggling will be treated as organised crime.

er the past two days. One of the teams reportedly intercepted a carriage truck and a four-wheeler early on Thursday. Jakeer was surprisingly found with the group. Upon noticing him, Chapadu Sub Inspector (SI) Chinna Peddaiah warned him to surrender,

while a constable tried to apprehend him. Jakeer reportedly tried to attack the police personnel with a knife, but the Sub Inspector fired two rounds in the air and another at Jakeer’s left leg, injuring him. Superintendent of Police (SP) Nachiket Vishwanath Shelke said red sanders smuggling would be dealt with as an organised crime, and the financial transactions of the accused would also be investigated. Mr. Nachiket observed that the red sanders, native to the Seshachalam forest, would be treated as national treasure. “Although there is widespread demand, nobody is allowed to fell the trees or transport the wood,” he added.

Karnataka forms SIT for fresh probe into rape-murder case

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Karnataka government has constituted a five-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) to conduct a fresh investigation into the 2012 case involving the brutal rape and murder of a 17-year-old girl on the outskirts of Dharmasthala. Inspector-General of Police N. Shashikumar has been appointed as the SIT chief. The government constituted the SIT following directions issued by the Supreme Court while hearing a special leave petition filed by Kusumavathi Gow-

da, mother of the victim. The court had directed the State government to complete the fresh investigation within three months and submit a report to the court, besides ordering the constitution of an SIT for the purpose. The SIT has been constituted with jurisdiction across Karnataka under the relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023, the order stated. The SIT has been given three months to complete the comprehensive probe and submit its final investigation report to the competent court. (With PTI inputs)

SPOTLIGHT



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi during a meeting with members of the local business community, Raebareilly, Uttar Pradesh. PTI

Covering the bases

Last year, the Congress set in motion the Sangathan Srijan Abhiyan, a process of rewiring its district leadership across India. This year, Rahul Gandhi is undertaking a renewed push towards public engagement bordering on activism, even as district leadership is being freed of past hierarchies. **Sandeep Phukan** examines the social re-engineering of the grand old party and how it intends to build up to the 2029 parliamentary election

When leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi sat on a dharna at Delhi's Parliament Street police station on August 21 to register a first information report (FIR) along with Sahil Lochab, one of the pellet-gun victims of police action during the students' agitation against paper leaks, he was trying out a new political playbook: sudden, swift action that catches the rival by surprise and pressures the authorities to act.

Exactly a month earlier, the Opposition leader had sat on an unannounced dharna outside the Prime Minister's residence, prompting senior ministers to rush in to listen to the Opposition's demands on the paper-leak issue.

After arriving at the police station around noon, Gandhi spent six hours before the cameras, exchanging words with police officials, eating *kathi* rolls for lunch and giving occasional soundbites to waiting television crews, until senior Home Ministry officials agreed to register an FIR on Lochab's complaint.

As images of Lochab and his mother with Gandhi went viral and the Congress claimed credit, many on social media felt that the Opposition had hit a "purple patch".

But can an individual leader's popularity translate into electoral dividends?

The recurring criticism is that the Congress lacks the organisational strength on the ground to convert goodwill into votes. In Hindi heartland States such as Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, the party's organisational machinery inspires little confidence, even among its supporters.

"While it is correct to argue that electoral victory of an organisation is consolidated by a charismatic leader, the charisma of a leader is translated into votes only if it is backed by organisational strength," says associate professor Kumar Sanjay Singh, who teaches history at Delhi University's Swami Shradhdhanand College.

However, this is not how the Congress has worked in the recent past as the party has often won elections riding on popular sentiments and the charisma of the Gandhis.

When the party was in power at the Centre for a decade (2004-2014) and in nearly a dozen States, AICC general secretaries spent more time in Delhi power centres than in States they were meant to handle.

By 2014, when the BJP swept the Lok Sabha polls, the party's organisation was hollowed out and its coffers were near empty.

That explains why the party is undertaking a massive organisational rewiring, alongside social re-engineering, under the Sangathan Srijan Abhiyan (SSA).

Until mid-September, nearly 1,000 District Congress Committee (DCC) presidents have been appointed across 25 States under the SSA. Adopted at the All India Congress Committee (AICC) session in Ahmedabad in April 2025, the exercise has been completed in most States.

Kerala and Assam, where Assembly elections were held earlier this year, are yet to undergo the restructuring.

Rebuilding the base

K.C. Venugopal, general secretary in-charge of organisation, or GSO, who is overseeing the ambitious revival plan, explains how the process works on the ground.

"Senior leaders go as AICC observers to a State



Even if one were to accept Congress's claims of effort to rebuild its organisation from grassroots to the top, especially in the Hindi heartland, whether this will be able to successfully challenge the electoral machine of the RSS-BJP is open to question.

KUMAR SANJAY SINGH
Associate professor, Swami Shradhdhanand College, DU



This government is playing with the future of our youth and Rahulji is at the forefront of raising their issues and becoming their voice. We will continue to follow that path and bring about real change.

K.K. VENUGOPAL
Congress general secretary in charge of organisation



and cover the districts where they identify and shortlist potential district committee leaders. They spend about 10-15 days, seeking opinion from workers, eminent citizens, activists and so on," Venugopal says.

He adds that the DCC president is usually appointed from the topmost contenders on a shortlist, which usually contains five or six names. "Only when there are serious differences, we consult Congress Legislature Party and Congress Working Committee (CWC) members. But even then, weightage is given to observers," he says.

The party has made the DCCs the focal point of the proposed turnaround process, with the emphasis on making its presence felt at the grassroots. From giving district offices a fresh coat of paint to framing national issues in local idioms and taking up district-specific concerns, suggestions are pouring in from AICC observers tasked with shortlisting district chiefs who can revive the party.

"In my 30 years in the Congress party, I have not come across such an elaborate exercise that involves leaders at every level," says Ashok Tanwar, a former Haryana Congress chief who re-joined the party after a stint in the BJP.

Tanwar, one of the top 10 AICC observers, who covered districts in Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh, says the exercise was not just about appointing DCC chiefs but also about identifying people who could be the party's link with the public. "There are many people who want to selflessly strengthen the party. All we have to do is identify and empower them," he said.

He claims the year-long campaign is beginning to show electoral results. "We have won a majority of the wards in Ajmer after 36 years. This is the power of SSA," says Tanwar, who was the observer for Ajmer, where urban local body polls were held this month.

Monitoring mechanism

Once appointed, the new DCC chiefs are monitored for their performance and effectiveness in carrying forward the party's ideology.

Every observer creates a WhatsApp group of district-level leaders to convey national campaigns as well as local issues.

Leaders are assessed on their participation in party programmes, with regular reports sent to

the GSO. Where a district chief is found wanting, there is provision to replace the leader.

"As and when we see some shortcoming, we make corrections," Venugopal says, pointing to cases in Uttarakhand, Haryana, and Odisha where leaders in some districts will be changed.

District chiefs are graded, with top performers placed in the A category and those in the D category liable to be replaced.

The observers are also marked on a scale of 100. The parameters include the quality of ground reports, choice of potential district chiefs, interaction with civil society, reporting of activities, and integrity and conduct.

"This campaign has certainly helped us rejuvenate the party at the lowest level. People at booth and block levels feel assured that the AICC is listening to their grievances," says Abdul Khaleque, former Lok Sabha member from Assam, who has been ranked the best-performing AICC observer. "At times factionalism, even at the most basic tier of the party structure, poses a challenge," says Khaleque, who was an observer for Madhya Pradesh, Jharkhand and West Bengal.

Intense factionalism is a product of entrenched hierarchies that do not accept change easily. There were no district-level committees in Haryana for 12 years.

Though powerful leaders such as Ghulam Nabi Azad, Kamal Nath, and Shakeel Ahmad were general secretaries in-charge of the State, they failed to build an effective organisation amid factionalism promoted by the satraps.

"The SSA is a policy decision of the party and everyone has to accept it. It is always better than an individual effort. That's why everyone in Haryana comes under one umbrella," says Tanwar.

Observers who do not want to be identified say they have witnessed underlying tensions between the old guard and younger leaders in States such as Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, and Rajasthan.

The silver lining, many say, is that the high command is mostly listening to the ground.

"In one or two cases, there are some suggestions to change the names that come up from the ground, but the party leadership goes with the observer's recommendations," says B.P. Singh, another top-performing observer, who travelled to Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, and Himachal Pradesh.



In my 30 years in the Congress party, I have not come across such an elaborate exercise that involves leaders at every level. There are many people who want to selflessly strengthen the party. All we have to do is identify and empower them.



ASHOK TANWAR
Former Haryana Congress chief



This campaign has certainly helped us rejuvenate the party at the lowest level. People at booth and block levels feel assured that the AICC is listening to their grievances. At times factionalism... poses a challenge.



ABDUL KHALEQUE
Former Lok Sabha member from Assam

Prof. Singh says that the Congress is out-matched by the organisational network of RSS-BJP in the Hindi heartland.

"Even if one were to accept Congress's claims of effort to rebuild its organisation from grassroots to the top, especially in the Hindi heartland, whether this will be able to successfully challenge the electoral machine of the RSS-BJP is open to question," he notes.

Securing social justice

While established leaders push for their acolytes, AICC observers have also been mandated to find effective leaders while ensuring representation for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, Other Backward Classes, minorities, and women.

An analysis of the 830 DCC presidents appointed until the end of August shows that 553, or 66.6%, belonged to SC, ST, OBC and minority communities. This is an increase of nearly 10% points over the earlier composition of district-level leadership.

Only 57 of the 830, or about 7%, are women. At the same time, 415, or 50%, of the new chiefs are below 50, in line with a resolution adopted by the party at Udaipur in 2022.

"We are not saying that the process is perfect but we are making a sincere attempt to change and get battle ready," says Venugopal. The battle he speaks about is the Parliamentary election of 2029.

Getting battle-ready

With the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls becoming one of the most contentious political issues, preparing booth-level agents from among the 16 lakh office-bearers is the top priority. The party wants a trained cadre capable of detecting alleged electoral malpractice.

After the Gen Z protests at Jantar Mantar over paper leaks, the thrust of the Congress's campaign has shifted towards youth outreach.

At its meeting on August 19, the Congress Working Committee approved a plan to expand Chhatron Ki Goonj (that loosely translates from Hindi to a student reverberation) to as many as 800 cities over the next few months.

This is an attempt to turn a series of student interactions into a nationwide programme.

Gandhi is likely to address as many as 28 student-interaction programmes under the campaign as the party seeks to build sustained outreach among young voters ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha election. Gen Z could account for roughly 25-30% of India's voting population by 2029, according to some demographic projections.

"This government is playing with the future of our youth and Rahulji is at the forefront of raising their issues and becoming their voice. We will continue to follow that path and bring about real change," Venugopal says.

The real test

Appointing DCC presidents and grading observers, and maintaining WhatsApp groups may bring discipline to a party whose structure has often been allowed to drift, but none of these measures by itself guarantees an active booth-level cadre.

The Congress has attempted several rounds of organisational renewal in the past, and State-level factionalism, the dominance of established leaders and the gap between the high command and the grassroots, have blunted them, say political commentators.

Greater representation of younger leaders and of SC, ST, OBC, and minority communities may widen the social base, but representation will have to translate into authority, resources, and electoral responsibility.

"Rahul has successfully built a narrative to stitch together a multilateral alliance, by bringing social justice, educational reform, and employment to the centre of the political discourse. He has also tapped into the populist psyche of the middle classes and the poor by launching a sharp critique on crony capitalism," Prof. Singh says, admitting that the response to Rahul's attacks on crony capitalism is at best tepid even within Congress.

The same applies to its student outreach efforts. The failure of the Congress's student wing, National Students Union of India, to win any seat in the students' body polls of the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) shows that perceived popularity or visibility of its leader is not enough to win elections.

The Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad, the student wing of the RSS, swept the DUSU polls. The DUSU setback is even more striking since it comes in a period when the Congress, since the Gen Z protests in July, is trying to build a narrative that the youth are moving away from the BJP.

"Since the Gen Z movement is triggered in Delhi, ABVP's electoral defeat would have gone a long way in consolidating this narrative," says Prof. Singh. He claims that the BJP reacted to this challenge with alacrity and Prime Minister Narendra Modi returned to the Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC), which had helmed his campaign in 2013, the year before he became Prime Minister.

"This time he spoke at the centenary celebrations of the college on September 5, just a fortnight before the DUSU election. The Congress, on the other hand, treats it as a run-of-the-mill election and misses the significance of timing in changing the momentum of politics," adds the academic.

For a party that has spent much of the past decade struggling to arrest its organisational decline, the Congress is attempting something beyond filling vacant posts, by changing the way its organisation is built – beginning not with the State leadership but with the district, block, and booth. The real test, however, will come at election time, when the new organisational architecture will be put to the test.

sandeep.phukan@thehindu.co.in



Anuj Kumar
anuj.kumar@thehindu.co.in

A haunting, fog-draped requiem for a vanishing way of life, young Ankur Hooda's *Khal Bachhda (The Calf Doll)* allegorically critiques what is sacrificed at the altar of progress. After winning international acclaim at its world premiere at the Copenhagen International Documentary Film Festival, the independent film in Haryanvi is one of eight selected for the prestigious documentary competition at the upcoming 70th BFI London Film Festival.

Set in Dayalpur village near Faridabad, the hybrid, para-fiction drama breathes through Satbir Singh Hooda, an elderly retired teacher. When his only cow delivers a stillborn calf and stops lactating, his quiet world tears open. Desperate to stave off losses, the educated farmer is left with no choice but to descend into a forbidden rural ritual where a life-like doll from the skin and body of the dead calf is crafted to trick the grieving mother into producing milk.

As he stitches the calf back together, deeper anxieties about identity and exploitation of the aging peasantry surface. Their children have moved to the cities, leaving them at the mercy of profit-seeking middlemen, armed

The price of progress

In Ankur Hooda's evocative docudrama, the ancient practice of crafting a calf doll becomes a powerful lens to examine the bond between villagers and their livestock

with oxytocin injections, urging farmers to liquidate their assets and tear off their emotional bond with the livestock. Skinning the calf becomes a visual metaphor for this mounting desperation to keep their lives and livelihoods intact.

"The practice of calf doll still exists. In northern India, it is mostly done with buffaloes, partly because of religious beliefs around cows and also a local belief that cows are smarter and a calf doll usually does not work on them. It is a banned practice, but a cost-effective way for villagers to keep milking the cow after a calf's death," relates the 25-year-old, who has cast his grandparents as themselves with a couple of

actors. "Casting them felt completely instinctive as the film emerges directly from their lived experiences."

Influenced by Turkish legend Nuri Bilge Ceylan, the self-taught filmmaker's imagery of rural life is shaped by devouring the works of Premchand and Chekhov. The

Vanishing ties (Left and below) Stills from *The Calf Doll*; (inset) director Ankur Hooda. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



film began with an image that stayed with him.

"One winter noon in my village, I saw my grandfather sitting alone, gazing at the neighbour's cow with a childlike desolation after having sold his own herd reluctantly. An element which had been his lifelong companion, an important one after retiring as an English lecturer especially. It made me wonder what is left of you when you no longer possess what has defined your entire life. That question became the seed, and I wanted to enquire about this metaphysical dilemma..."

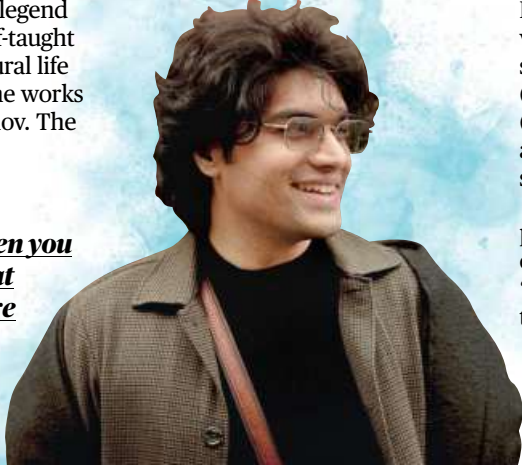
For his grandfather, Ankur says, the cattle were never simply livestock. "They were work, companionship, routine and perhaps most importantly, a part of who he was. The film grew out

of my attempt to understand that relationship."

Ankur says in Haryana, private dairies have shifted the older relationship between farmers and their cattle, turning livestock more into an economic calculation. "I have heard about several cases where the dairies intentionally kill calves to save costs of raising one and use illegal oxytocin injections instead, which are cheaper. All of this is linked with migration that created a gap between supply and demand of milk, which the dairies fill in."

Ankur says he abandoned the idea of a script and improvised everything while interacting with the real spaces and characters of his village. "I was spending time in these rural spaces along with my film comrades. More than a challenge, the lack of money gave us immense freedom. It is shot in DIY fashion with the help of villagers, friends, and family. We shot it on (DOP) Anish (Sara) and (creative producer) Achal's (Mishra) small personal DSLRs, and borrowed basic lenses and sound recorders from friends."

For Ankur, the film is a prologue to a longer exploration of the region through a trilogy. "I'm interested in documenting that dissonance between people and landscapes that are slowly fading as inevitable modernity moves in, and preserving some of those stories before they disappear with them."



What is left of you when you no longer possess what has defined your entire life? That question became the seed

ANKUR HOODA
Director

Flowers made of thread

Designer Sunaina Suneja brings together timeless works to unravel the stories held within phulkari



Stitch a tale An installation at the exhibition. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Taran in Punjab, Suneja found herself learning the craft all over again, this time with the added task of teaching it.

Suneja examined borders, central panels and individual motifs, comparing them across textiles. She was particularly interested in what she calls the *pehchaan*, or identity motif of phulkari; the visual vocabulary that allows one to recognise the craft beyond a generic floral embroidery. A *sainchi*, for instance, led her to a book featuring a strikingly similar piece. It suggested not necessarily a one-off design, but a repertoire of forms that could be repeated and adapted.

That is also why Suneja resists the idea that phulkari has a fixed appearance. Chand bagh, pachranga, darshan dwāra and sona chandni reveal different arrangements of colour, geometry and motif.

"Phulkari could have been any flower," she says. "On this one, you see flowers. On another, you see geometry." The textiles also carry stories of women, marriage and departure. One *vari da bagh* on loan was given to a friend's grandmother when she married at 13. A *chope* was traditionally associated with a bride's wedding rituals, including the bath that marked her last such ritual in her maternal home.

That may be what lingers in the exhibition's title: fragments of a language, some documented and some forgotten, that continue to reveal itself when someone looks closely enough.

The exhibition is on till October 1 at Art Gallery, Kamaladevi Complex, India International Centre, 40, Max Mueller Marg, Monday-Sunday, 11am -7pm.

Geetika Sachdev

The first piece in textile designer and revivalist Sunaina Suneja's exhibition, *Phulkari: A Lingering Presence*, is displayed in reverse, exposing the stitches and loose threads usually hidden from sight.

"There is a reason for it," says Suneja. "Traditionally, phulkari was worked on like this. All the emotions were being poured on this side."

It is an apt beginning to a showcase that brings together vintage textiles from Suneja's collection with contemporary works. Suneja's engagement with phulkari began in 2008, through a project in villages around Nabha intended to generate income for women. It took two-and-a-half years to get the project off the ground.

Thread-counting was not a matter of following a pattern; the embroiderer had to develop an eye for the weave, knowing instinctively where the needle should enter and how many threads to pick up. An elderly woman who wandered into one of the early training sessions provided an unexpected clue. She said she had embroidered in her youth and demonstrated a few stitches from the reverse. For a later project in Tarn



A village cast in brass

Fashion designer-turned-artist Jenjum Gadi returns to his Galo roots in a new show, turning food crops and Nature into sculpture

Tanushree Ghosh
tanushree.ghosh@thehindu.co.in

It was quite comical that just as Jenjum Gadi was talking of how gardens inspire his art, his gardener, who tends his Hauz Khas terrace garden, had already called him thrice. "My *maali* is not perfect but I love him," says the artist with a green thumb and an elephant's memory.

Jenjum, 44, belongs to the Galo tribe that lives in the non-touristy Tirbin village, in Lower Siang district of the eastern Himalayas in Arunachal Pradesh. For the last 20 years, he has made Delhi home.

Describing himself as one among Arunachal Pradesh's first fashion designers, with two decades of shaping the runway, Jenjum, says, "after 20 years, for me, fashion was done". Fabric

gave way to metal. All the "beautiful clothes" he made would always end up "on a hanger, in cupboards", he says.

Jenjum adds, "The Northeast is now mainstream in fashion, but that transition hasn't really happened in art." Two years ago, he shifted gears to become an artist, and has already done four shows, including one at Art Mumbai.

From digging into his early memories of his mother's garden for his first exhibition *Apase -*



The Northeast is now mainstream in fashion, but that transition hasn't really happened in art

JENJUM GADI
Artist

Art and childhood (Left) Artist Jenjum Gadi; (below) artworks titled *Amo Tami*; (inset) Ayo Gv Doyw. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



From My Mother's Garden (2024), the canvas is now wider to include his Tirbin village in *Ngok Dolu (My Village)*. Looking at the gilded life-sized installations of food crops and vegetation, it is hard to not think of Jenjum as Tulsi Chakraborty from Satyajit Ray's fantasy comedy *Parash Pathar* (1958), whose philosopher's stone turns things into gold.

Gadi's choice of metal is brass. "In our culture, brass metal is used to make *urlis* and big plates. These antique pieces are exchanged at weddings and have come down through generations, often through trade from Tibet. Brass has a unique quality. As it ages, it develops a patina, telling the story of its surroundings, mimicking the natural world," the artist says.

East meets West

A mature banana tree here, a young brinjal plant there, bitter-gourd creepers and okra work titled *Benju* – how his grandmother pronounced the vegetable's name. Snippets of personal history, thus, get memorialised. Amid the 42 works on show stands a circular wall-mounted work, titled *Ane* (mother). It shows his earliest memory of his mother sitting at the loom, weaving clothes, her back to him. She is seated on a lotus flower, like a goddess.

In Jenjum's works, brass meets Pichhwai. The Rajasthani devotional art drew him, because "it depicts the natural

surroundings: flora and fauna, peacocks, streams, cows strolling past. It took me back to my village. Nature is deeply knit with our existence," says the animist, who sees Pichhwai less as an image of a god than as "a spiritual connection, like a poem". Before his first brass show, Jenjum did a show of around 10 collections of Pichhwai on raw silk.

The village is changing

He feels sad that the mountains of his childhood now have smaller trees, felled for easier farming. Jenjum rues, "My village is changing. All the beautiful bamboo houses are being converted into concrete. The innocence is going away." But he's most concerned about "deforestation and ecological disbalance". When he returns home, "I can see the forests being cut, the rivers drying up, the small streams we caught fish in becoming non-existent," he says.

Beyond himself, Jenjum wants to "bring out the Northeast's talent in art, its myriad forms, and give them exposure." He has recently registered an art company called Northeast India Public Art Trust. "We have no dearth of talent, but there's no proper channel," he says.

Ngok Dolu (My Village) is on show till September 30, 11am-7pm, at Gallery Vayu, Lodhi Road.

Fresh breath of life

An exhibition recalls the glorious past of the havelis of the Shekhawati region



Dusting heritage Rang Mahal at Arun Poddar haveli. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Shailaja Tripathi

For generations, Shekhawati's grand havelis have stood as reminders of a time when wealthy Marwari families built elaborate homes in this area in northern Rajasthan and then left for bigger cities. In the absence of care, the painted havelis, which were once a symbol of the community's wealth and status, began decaying. Many of the owners did not return. Now, there are signs that the story is changing.

An exhibition, *Raj Se Swaraj Tak - From Colonial Rule to Freedom, Through the Eyes of Shekhawati*, at the Visual Arts Gallery, brings together around 1,000 objects to tell the story of the region over the last two centuries. Curated by Shruti Nada Poddar, founder of MOHAR (Museum of Heritage and Art at Ramgarh) and art historian Alka Pande, the exhibition draws on Shruti's 12-year-old personal collection as well as objects found in the havelis she has acquired and restored. The exhibition showcases 10 journeys through Shekhawati, beginning with its architecture and painted walls and moving through the lives of saints, trade and global connections, the influence of the British Raj, changing lifestyles, and finally the Shekhawati diaspora's return to the region.

The painted haveli towns of Shekhawati were added to UNESCO's Tentative List in 2026, a crucial step in the World Heritage Site process.

The exhibition also marked the launch of *Shruti's Handbook of Heritage Conservation: Special Focus - Havelis of Shekhawati*.

The exhibition is at Visual Arts Gallery, India Habitat Centre, Lodhi Road, till September 30.



A nation’s song

Vande Mataram’s rendition must be in the spirit of unity in diversity

Patriotism is not just reverence for a territory or a flag but is the embodiment of solidarity with fellow citizens in a nation-state. The idea of a nation as a bond transcends family, community or faith, uniting citizens through common values and a pursuit of prosperity. National symbols and anthems exist to hone that bond. When they are changed or modified to compel citizens to accept a majoritarian version, their purpose is defeated. India’s freedom fighting generation understood this. Which is why, in 1937, the Congress Working Committee resolved that only the first two stanzas of Bankim Chatterjee’s *Vande Mataram* should be sung at national gatherings, since the later stanzas invoke the motherland as Hindu deities. When *Jana Gana Mana* was adopted as the National Anthem on January 24, 1950, India’s first President Rajendra Prasad said that *Vande Mataram*, even though there is no mention of a “national song” in the Constitution, would be “honoured equally”. Since then, the two-stanza version has allowed citizens of all faiths to partake in a song that stirred the freedom struggle and popularised by artists such as Lata Mangeshkar and A.R. Rahman.

In the last year or so, the BJP-led Union government has sought to unsettle this inclusive compact. Since the song’s 150th anniversary in 2025, it has pushed for all six stanzas to be recited. The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) issued directions and circulars in 2026 and Parliament passed the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Act, 2026 with little debate – actions that are in line with the BJP’s habit of imposing uniformity and majoritarian preference on all citizens. The amendment extends Section 3 of the 1971 Act, which punishes anyone who intentionally prevents the singing of the National Anthem or disturbs an assembly engaged in such singing, to the National Song. *Per se* it does not compel anyone to sing or define the National Song or its stanzas. But read alongside the MHA orders, which prescribe an official version of all six stanzas, mandate mass singing at public functions, and place the song before the anthem, it amounts to compulsion, as a petition by T.M. Krishna in the Supreme Court has argued. The Court has rightly observed that the state may decide what the National Song is, but cannot penalise conscientious objectors in line with *Bijoe Emmanuel* (1986). This judgment held that no law obliges anyone to sing the Anthem, standing in respectful silence is no offence and executive instructions without statutory backing cannot curtail fundamental rights. The Court must apply *Bijoe Emmanuel* in full, set aside the MHA’s orders and make it clear that silence cannot be read as “disturbance”. By reverting to the vision of the freedom generation, the Court will do justice to the idea of unity in diversity.

A chance to retreat

The Greenland agreement allows Donald Trump to scale down his threats

President Donald Trump first raised the possibility of acquiring Greenland, a Danish territory, during his first term in office. After his return to the White House in January 2025, he doubled down on his threat, saying that he would make the island American territory one way or the other. This incensed Denmark, a founding member of NATO, as well as America’s other allies in Europe. Denmark reassessed its sovereignty over the island but, as a compromise, promised to let the U.S. expand its military presence. On September 22, the leaders of the U.S., Denmark and Greenland signed a new security deal, which, according to Mr. Trump, would allow the U.S. to do “what is necessary in Greenland”. For Mr. Trump, who had even raised the possibility of using force to take over the territory, the deal is a retreat from his acquisition demand. But at the same time, it re-endorses the U.S. role as the primary security provider – it already stations some 150 troops in Greenland at its Pituffik Space Base. Under the agreement, Washington would build military facilities in Narsarsuaq in the south, where the U.S. had an airfield during the Second World War, and in Mestersvlg in the east, along the Norwegian Sea.

The 1951 U.S.-Denmark security agreement provides Washington the broad rights to build military bases in the ice-covered island. During the Second World War and the Cold War, the U.S. had more than 30 bases and installations on the island. Most were shut down over the years, particularly after the Cold War. In recent years, Trump administration officials raised concerns about the growing activities of China and Russia in the Arctic, including alleged espionage. As the Arctic region’s strategic profile is rising – partly because melting ice opens up previously impassable regions – the U.S. wants to consolidate its position and believes that Greenland would play a key role in that strategy. The agreement says that even if Greenland, which has a population of around 50,000, becomes independent, it would respect the deal with the U.S. and stay in NATO. In other words, this provides the U.S. indefinite access to the island’s military facilities. The deal also stipulates that no hostile power (non-NATO countries) can establish military facilities in Greenland or invest in its sensitive areas (mainly rare earths). Denmark has already blocked Chinese investments in the territory and the deal effectively formalises that restriction. So, on paper, Greenland could remain a self-governing, autonomous territory within the Kingdom of Denmark, while the U.S. would be its strategic patron with greater control – a diplomatic arrangement acceptable to Washington, NATO and Denmark.

One of the enduring ironies of the Indian political system is that political parties, which are considered the principal stakeholders of electoral democracy, do not find a mention in the Constitution, except in the Tenth Schedule. They exist as “associations” in furtherance of the fundamental rights under Article 19. No effort has been made to define and straitjacket their legal character to conform to being a company, trust, society, firm or a not-for-profit company. Even so, they continue to enjoy the benefit of income-tax exemption in an unprecedented and unparalleled manner, sometimes becoming mysterious receptacles of inexplicable monies. Just as there are shell companies that fulfil unstated purposes, there are shell political parties that serve an insidious intent. And thereby hangs a tale.

The mystery of political funding

That tale was partially unravelled by a recent BBC investigation that revealed extraordinary donations received by six Registered Unrecognised Political Parties (RUPPs). A well-known yet intriguing aspect of Indian politics – ugly and ubiquitous – stands exposed. Political parties and their benefactors thrive in this system, even if it appears reprehensible, unlawful and disturbing.

Earlier, the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR) released a report on July 18, 2025, which found a 223% rise in the declared income of RUPPs in FY2022-23. It noted that, of the 2,764 RUPPs, only 739 had submitted their financial records for the year to the Election Commission of India (ECI), the sole custodian, under the law, of the fate and fortunes of political parties.

In a press note, “Cleaning up the Electoral System” (August 9, 2025), the ECI said it had ‘delisted’ 334 RUPPs out of 2,854 “as part of a comprehensive and continuous strategy...to clean up the electoral system.” It would be interesting to see whether the six parties in question are part of the ECI’s “continuous strategy”.

On October 16, 1994, T.N. Seshan, then Chief Election Commissioner of India, issued an order under the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968, in which he highlighted the “adhocism” and the “sorry state of affairs prevailing in almost all political parties in the country, whether recognised National or State parties or registered-unrecognised parties”. He observed, “I have yet to come across any party whose affairs are being run in accordance with the provisions of its constitution or rules and regulations.” Through the order, T.N. Seshan put all political parties on “notice” to set their house in order, declaring that the ECI would not remain a “mute spectator”. In subsequent guidelines prescribing the format for registration under Section 29A of the Representation of the People Act (RPA), 1951, the ECI stated in paragraph 3(xxiii) that a party seeking registration must declare in its constitution that it will contest elections within five years of registration and that, if it does not “contest elections continuously



Ashok Lavasa

Former Election Commissioner of India and a former Union Finance Secretary

The Election Commission of India should scrutinise political parties and political finance rather than legitimate voters

for six years”, it shall “be automatically taken off the list of recognised parties”.

“Taking off” or ‘delisting’ does not mean deregistration, as the ECI is not generally empowered to deregister political parties. Similarly, even if RUPPs are ‘unrecognised’, they remain eligible to receive contributions under Section 29B of the RPA, while their tax treatment is governed by Section 13A of the Income-tax Act. “Recognition” is governed by Order 6 of the Election Symbols Order, which distinguishes between ‘recognized’ and ‘unrecognized’ political parties for the purpose of allotting symbols and lays down the criteria for their classification. T.N. Seshan amended the Symbols Order and introduced Order 16A, which empowers the ECI to “suspend or withdraw recognition of a recognised political party for its failure to observe MCC [Model Code of Conduct] or follow lawful directions and instructions of the Commission”. That provision sits, rather harmlessly, in the statute book, empowering an ECI that has generally been reluctant to strike.

Hence, whether ‘delisted’ or ‘unrecognized’, the parties remain eligible to receive contributions. It is a matter for investigation whether such donations continued to qualify for tax exemptions, given that the intent behind the delisting was to disqualify them.

The scale of ‘political wealth’

A paper published by Venkatesh Nayak, a senior researcher at the Commonwealth Human Rights Initiative (which was also reported by a leading media site), revealed that 22 political parties collectively had ₹18,742.31 crore at their disposal for the 2024 general election. This included funds in their kitty when the election was announced and ₹7,416.31 crore in donations raised between the announcement and the completion of the election. After the election, these parties had ₹14,848.46 crore remaining in their custody, including cash in hand, money held in bank accounts and fixed deposits, after incurring ₹3,861.57 crore in election-related expenditure during the campaign period, according to the accounts submitted to the ECI.

The study found that, over the last decade, the exchequer ‘lost’ ₹11,813 crore in taxes due to exemptions for political donations, with individual donors and Hindu Undivided Families overtaking corporates in donating to political parties. In FY2022-23, individual donors claimed exemptions worth ₹2,275.85 crore, dwarfing corporate claims of ₹514.4 crore and those of firms and associations, at ₹115.71 crore. Declared donations to political parties increased from ₹714 crore (43 parties) in 2015-16 to ₹7,203 crore (27 parties) in 2023-24. Yet, only 41.76% of total donations, amounting to ₹28,287 crore over nine years, were claimed as tax-exempt, raising questions about the remaining 58%. Mr. Nayak asks: “What incentives are driving them to donate without tax relief? The lack of transparency obscures answers.”

What added the thickest layer of secrecy was

the so-called reform of electoral bonds introduced by the ruling party in 2018, which made the entire business of political finance murky. Although the scheme was declared unconstitutional by the Supreme Court of India in 2024, the details of the donations subsequently disclosed raised questions that remain unanswered. Most RUPPs were not eligible to receive electoral bonds, as they were restricted to parties that had “secured at least 1% of the votes in the latest Lok Sabha or State Legislative Assembly elections”. Who, then, made these contributions, and why?

The top court and ECI must act

Political parties have shown scant interest in transparency. They united in resisting the 2013 order of the Central Information Commission (CIC) bringing them under the Right to Information Act. Interestingly, besides the CIC, neither the ECI nor the Supreme Court has shown any inclination to enforce it. The Income-Tax Department and the Enforcement Directorate might not consider it a priority to scrutinise the accounts of political parties as they do those of ordinary taxpayers. The ECI lacks the mandate, intent or wherewithal to question the accounts mechanically submitted by political parties. Submission of the accounts is enough to comply with the letter of the law, even if its spirit gasps. How will that spirit be revived, and who will revive it?

It is incumbent upon the Court to order a court-monitored probe into the saga of electoral bonds and the alleged *quid pro quo* in the petitions pending before it. The probe should also examine the phenomenon of ‘insignificant’ RUPPs receiving and spending huge contributions without participating in the electoral process in any substantial manner. Surely, such “shell” parties cannot justify spending crores as “administrative expenses”.

Exercising its powers under Article 324 – described by the Court in the landmark judgment of *Kanhiya Lal Omar vs R.K. Trivedi and Others* as a “reservoir of authority” for the ECI – the ECI should order political parties to have their accounts audited by the Comptroller and Auditor General of India or its nominee. It should also consider imposing a limit on expenditure by political parties during elections, a measure it has recommended repeatedly. Tax exemptions on donations should be limited to the prescribed expenditure limit. All other donations that enrich the parties should be fully taxed.

The ECI should establish an automatic procedure to ‘deregister’ any RUPP that does not contest elections in accordance with its guidelines and develop a centralised digital portal where all registered parties can upload their financial data in standardised formats.

Let the ECI spend its energy and authority on ‘purifying’ the electoral environment rather than on chasing genuine electors off the electoral rolls. Until then, ‘We the People’ must continue to scream *‘Hami yaha chhau* (we are here”).

Policing the line between publicity and justice

Within minutes of an arrest anywhere in India today, a face – handcuffed, flanked by policemen, sometimes garlanded with placards cataloguing the crime – starts circulating on social media, often before the accused is produced before a magistrate. A Supreme Court of India PIL seeking a nationwide media protocol/police media briefings has forced a question that Indian policing has quietly avoided: under what law do we do this, should we do it, and where should it stop?

Photographs of wanted persons and reward notices have solved crimes, helped recover missing children, and brought fugitives to book years after trails went cold – the public, alerted, has done what a thinly stretched police force alone could not.

The justification is strong; the legal architecture is weak. What is needed is a clear legal basis, not a habit inherited from mere precedent.

Current law and practice

No single statute permits or prohibits police from publishing photographs of accused persons. What exists is a patchwork of colonial-era regulations, an identification statute and the general architecture of criminal procedure.

Section 84 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023 (Section 82 of the Code of Criminal Procedure or CrPC) allows courts to proclaim absconders and publish proclamations in newspapers. It says nothing about photographs, but attaching one has become settled practice because it serves the purpose of securing the person’s appearance. This judicial process is triggered only after a warrant fails; it does not, however, provide a basis for publicity at the investigation stage.

Publication at the investigation stage rests instead on the general powers of an investigating



Rupin Sharma

IPS officer who is the Director General of Police, Nagaland

Before releasing the photograph of a person accused, arrested, but not yet tried, police must ask whether the investigation requires it

officer (Io): every person must assist the police in preventing and investigating offences, and an Io may examine anyone with relevant information. Publishing photographs on social media to solicit identification, trace absconders or find witnesses is a digital-age extension of the old “Hue and Cry Notice”, in State Police Manuals – provisions that predate Independence and whose language (“description of the subject”) is broad enough to plausibly cover photographs and rewards.

Reward announcements stand on firmer, narrower ground, typically governed by State Police Regulations under the Police Act, 1861, which vest sanctioning authority in a hierarchy ranging from the Station House Officer (SHO) to the State government. No prior warrant or proclamation is required; it is an exercise of administrative discretion, not a judicial precondition. The Criminal Procedure (Identification) Act, 2022, governs the taking, storage and use of measurements – including photographs – for identification, but is often wrongly cited as enabling their publication. It says nothing, however, about circulating them.

Constitutional limits

Article 21, jurisprudence has sharpened, not softened. Presumption of innocence remains central to criminal justice, and courts increasingly recognise that broadcasting an arrested person’s face as a fait accompli of guilt, before any charge is framed can cause real, irreversible harm. The Rajasthan High Court termed such practices “institutional humiliation” digital circulation is permanent, searchable and indifferent to later acquittal.

The Bureau of Police Research and Development prepared a draft manual on media briefings by police personnel and shared it with the Ministry of Home Affairs in July 2024. In January 2026, the Supreme Court said the *amicus*

had prepared a Police Manual for Media Briefing and directed the States to evolve appropriate policies based on it within three months. Some categories are already absolute red lines: a juvenile in conflict with the law cannot be identified except in the child’s best interest and with the Juvenile Justice Board’s permission; a sexual assault survivor’s identity is protected by law. The intriguing debate concerns the ordinary adult – accused, arrested, but not yet tried.

The distinction that matters

Publication sits on a scale: at one end, legitimate investigative necessity – crime prevention, public order and law-and-order purposes; at the other, the showcasing of police achievements. . Photographs released merely to showcase arrests serve police optics at the accused’s expense and can prejudice public opinion before trial.

American law treats “wanted” notices as public-record exceptions to privacy law, but agencies are trained to frame them carefully – “alleged,” “wanted for questioning” – to preserve the presumption of innocence even while seeking help. British policing, more conservatively, withholds arrested persons’ identities altogether.

What is needed is not an outright ban on soliciting public assistance – that would be legally unwarranted and self-defeating – but a codified, uniform national protocol that distinguishes proportionate, need-based disclosure from prejudicial publicity; mandates blackout categories such as juveniles and sexual-offence complainants; requires time-bound review and takedown once the investigative purpose is served or an accused is discharged or acquitted; and applies uniformly across States.

One question before any photograph goes out could be a beginning: is the disclosure necessary to the investigation, or merely convenient to the narrative?

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

State of the ECI

The Special Intensive Revision (SIR), one feels, is turning out to be a failed exercise in the country. Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar appears to have failed the Constitution and the people of the nation in the conduct of the

SIR. He should resign (Page 1, “Opposition calls for CEC’s exit over ‘illegal conduct’”, September 24). That said, why did Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi remain silent for so long over their differences with the CEC on SIR deletions and related

issues, when the electoral damage has already been caused? There is something more to it than meets the eye. This is a constitutional crisis in the country. **S. Ramakrishnasayee**, Chennai

It is really astonishing to see the way things have been

unfolding at the Election Commission of India over the last few months. While everyone expects an autonomous constitutional body to function democratically, it appears to have become a one-man show under the leadership of Gyanesh Kumar. He has centralised

decision-making, lending credibility to the serious allegations made by the Opposition parties. **Kolikonda Sarathbabu**, Khammam, Telangana

It is extremely worrying to find the CEC in the eye of a storm. A position that shapes the destiny and fate

of the nation in the midst of a serious controversy does not augur well for the nation. Corrective action needs to be taken on a war footing.

Balasubramaniam Pavani, Secunderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Should permanent membership, veto powers of the UNSC be abolished?



Amitabh Mattoo
Dean of School of International Studies, JNU



Swaran Singh
Former Professor of the School of International Studies, JNU

PARLEY

In the ongoing session of the UN General Assembly (UNGA), France has made a proposal to enhance the functioning of the UN, especially in dealing with collective security and the use of veto. France has been advocating that the use of veto in the UN Security Council (UNSC) be “regulated” when it comes to dealing with humanitarian crises such as in Sudan, Lebanon or in cases of genocide. France believes that the use of veto is not a matter of “privilege” but of “responsibility”. So, should permanent membership and veto powers of the UN Security Council be abolished? Amitabh Mattoo and Swaran Singh discuss the question in a conversation moderated by Kallol Bhattacharjee. Edited excerpts:

Is it realistically possible to imagine an UNSC where veto would be “regulated” as the French proposal suggested?

Amitabh Mattoo: What Emmanuel Macron (President of France) articulated in the UNGA on September 22 is not entirely new. What we are seeing is really a renewed push behind what used to be called the French-Mexican initiative, first launched in 2015, under which permanent members of the SC would voluntarily refrain from using the veto in situations involving genocide, crimes against humanity, and large-scale war crimes. It’s not an attempt to abolish the veto or amend the UN charter. It’s essentially an exercise in self-restraint by the P5 (permanent members of the UNSC: U.S., U.K., France, China and Russia). What gives the initiative fresh significance is not just Mr. Macron’s speech, but the political momentum behind it. France and Mexico both announced this week that 128 states now support the declaration, with 21 joining in the last four months. And the significant part is that the U.K., another P5 country, has now joined France in accepting the principle.

So for the first time, two of the five permanent members have committed themselves to this form of voluntary restraint.

But I think we should also distinguish between three different questions which are often conflated – the use of the veto, accountability for the use of the veto, and the much larger question of reform of the Security Council. Mr. Macron’s initiative addresses only the first. It says in effect, even if the veto remains, surely there must be circumstances of exceptional human suffering in which a permanent member agrees not to exercise it. It is, as I said, a modest incremental proposition institutionally, but potentially significant



A general view of the UNGA in New York City, U.S., on September 22. REUTERS

normatively in terms of what we want the world to be like. It seeks to change the political behaviour of the five permanent countries without undertaking what seems to be the almost impossible task of rewriting the charter. So, it’s a modest proposal and it has got some momentum, but whether it translates into reality, we’ll have to wait and see.

Does the current situation in UNGA indicate that the P5 is now divided between the France-U.K. and Russia-U.S.-China factions on the use of veto?

Swaran Singh: Clearly, the U.K. and France are not the heavyweights among the P5. Therefore, I think it is easier for France and the U.K. to make that principled position saying that the P5, which wield veto power, should be able to better regulate or manage how fundamentally the power is utilised; to make sure that the UNSC is able to take action and that it does not get paralysed. In fact, the contradiction of 2013 itself was driven by the fact that in the civil war in Syria, Chinese and Russian vetoes were making it impossible for the UNSC to pass any resolution condemning Syria. After the August 2013 chemical weapons attack in Ghouta in September, the then French President Francois Hollande had in his speech proposed a ‘code of good conduct’ for the UNSC. This is where, for the first time, a kind of proposition was made that the P5 could voluntarily restrain the use of veto in cases of genocide, crimes against humanity or larger war crimes. I think the attempt was to skirt amending the UN Charter and still make it much more contemporaneous. None of the P5 are talking of eliminating veto power that they have. There are multiple versions among the five as to how they wish to reform the UN Security Council.

As an ideal, we believe that we live in a world



As an ideal, we believe that we live in a world of sovereign equality, but in reality, because of the way power is distributed, it is impossible for any international organisation to survive – not just become effective – but even survive if they happen to take a decision against any of the major powers

SWARAN SINGH

of sovereign equality, but in reality, because of the way power is distributed, it is impossible for any international organisation to survive – not just become effective – but even survive if they happen to take a decision against any of the major powers. Incidentally, veto is not a word mentioned in the UN Charter and it was created through a separate mechanism. But the premise is that any international organisation must not take a decision against the fundamental interests of any major power if they wish to survive.

While doubts persist about the veto, the question is will veto continue to be extended to new members of the UNSC whenever they are inducted?

AM: Apart from Mr. Macron’s or the France-Mexican initiative, there have been incremental reforms which fall short of trying to amend the UN Charter. There was an earlier Liechtenstein initiative, which was adopted by the UNGA in 2022, which took a different route. It did not prevent a permanent member from exercising the veto. Instead, whenever a veto was cast, the General Assembly would be convened within 10 working days to debate the issue. In other words, a veto will no longer be allowed to simply terminate the conversation. The permanent member concerned would have to explain and defend its action on the floor of the UNGA. That was one initiative which was passed by the UNGA. A third initiative, also similar to the French-Mexican initiative, is the ‘ACT code of conduct’ or the Accountability, Coherence and Transparency Initiative. This goes beyond the P5 and asks members of the Security Council, including the non-permanent members, not to vote against credible action designed to prevent or halt genocide, crimes against humanity and war crimes.

Again, its strength is moral and political rather than legally coercive. So I would resist the debate as being simply ‘retain or abolish the veto’. We now have several overlapping approaches – abolition, extension of the veto to new permanent members in the name of equality, voluntary restraint in case of

mass atrocities, political accountability after a veto is exercised, and the final question of broader structural reform of the Security Council itself. So my own analytical conclusion would be that Mr. Macron’s proposal matters precisely because it is pragmatic; reformist rather than revolutionary. Formal abolition of the veto would ultimately require charter amendment and the consent of the very permanent members whose privilege is being removed.

Can you please explain the issue of accountability in the debate on veto?

AM: Short of an amendment of the UN Security Council; an amendment of the veto provisions; or the larger restructuring of the UN Security Council, I think there is great merit in the ‘Liechtenstein initiative’, whereby the debate would continue within the UNGA. It would not prevent or terminate the conversation from happening in the floor of the UNGA, where the permanent member which has exercised the veto would have to clearly demonstrate to the members of the UN what the reasons were behind the exercise of the veto, especially when it has vetoed an action designed to prevent or halt genocide or crimes against humanity.

Calling upon the permanent member to explain and defend its actions would not necessarily prevent anything when there is real national self-interest at stake, but at least it will make the permanent members, one of the P5 countries which has exercised the veto, become a little more cautious in the use of its power because it would know that it would need to justify and become accountable for its action.

Is the French proposal transparent or honest about the framing of certain conflicts that are going on such as the Israeli campaign in the Gaza Strip?

SS: I think words such as honesty and justice are most misused in international relations. There is no doubt that all the UN members, whether they are in the Security Council or in the General Assembly, come to the world’s largest platform with their own interpretations, with their own understanding of each of these conflicts that you just listed. So in that sense, there is this important difficulty of word versus the spirit of various international law regimes or the Charter of the United Nations.



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NOTEBOOK

How rare archival photos revealed the magic of Madras

‘Madras on Stage’, the fourth edition of The Hindu’s ‘Made of Chennai’ archives exhibition showcased the rich cultural heritage of the city

K. Arunkumar

“Madras on Stage,” the fourth edition of *The Hindu*’s ‘Made of Chennai’ photo archives exhibition – held at Kasturi Buildings, the newspaper’s corporate head office – concluded on September 15. This year’s exhibition attracted a larger crowd than previous years, and notables from various walks of life visited it.

We at the Library Department, which serves as the archives of *The Hindu*, started collecting photographs for the exhibition in the second week of July. The curator, Thirupurasundari Sevel, suggested a division of 33% performing arts (national and international), 33% drama/stage, and 33% cinema. We chose to display pictures from the 1920s all the way to the 2010s to ensure that we did not miss out on any cultural activities or performing arts. We have in our repository nearly 2.5 to 3 million pictures across varied subjects, which include digital copies, black-and-white and colour prints, negatives, and colour transparencies. Of these physical prints, negatives, and transparencies, 60% were readily available in digital format; for the rest, we had to search through physical copies.

The curator gave us helpful clues and ideas. She also shared a timeline of key programmes and cultural events in Madras over the years. Using these leads, we cross-checked news items published in *The Hindu* and *Sport & Pastime* (a magazine published by The Hindu Group from 1947 to 1968), confirmed the dates, and searched our archives for pictures.

Finding some photos was tough, such as the 1927 photograph of Pammal Sambanda Mudaliar with the cast of his play by the Suguna Vilasa Sabha. Tracking down cinema stills of M.K. Thyagaraja Bhagavathar (MKT) shot in Madras was similarly exhausting. We hold only very few photographs from MKT’s films; the 1934 musical *Pavalakkodi*, directed by K. Subrahmanyam, provided the sole Madras-based still in our collection.

On the brighter side, we came across photographs of many international performers who appeared in Madras from the 1950s to the 1990s, including Boney. M, American jazz musicians, Egyptian folk dancers, Tibetan Amdo drama troupes, Russian Ramayana casts, and Russian ballet dancers. We collected a total of 600 pictures and shortlisted 181. Out of these, 100 pictures were physically exhibited, while all 181 were displayed on a television screen at the venue.

Right from the inauguration on August 14, school and college students visited the exhibition almost daily. Film and drama personalities, politicians, journalists, and public officials were among the other notable visitors. The exhibition was inaugurated by Tamil Nadu Minister for School Education, Tamil Development and Information A. Rajmohan. Tamil Nadu Minister for Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments S. Ramesh also toured the display.

Historian and heritage activist V. Sriram appreciated the exhibits and helped identify several figures in the photographs – updates we have since incorporated into our archival captions.

Actor Pasupathy, whose photo from his Koothu-p-Pattarai days was on display, visited with his family and spotted a familiar face in the frame – retired Justice Prabha Sridevan, his co-star in *The Conduct of Life*, a play by Maria Irene Fornes. Actress and activist Revathi also dropped by, thrilled to spot three photographs capturing her participation in various social causes.

Other notable visitors included drama veterans Kathadi S. Ramamurthy, S.Ve. Shekher, and Madhu Balaji; theatre and television artist S. Varadarajan; cartoonist Madhan; singer Chinmayi; actor-journalist Chitra Lakshmanan; filmmaker Halitha Shameem; screenplay-dialogue writer Anand Kumaresan; and cinema PROs Diamond Babu and Nikhil Murukan.

We’re already looking forward to celebrating Madras again next year.

arunkumar.k@thehindu.co.in

PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Panorama of colour



Lightning strikes seen over the city skyline in Mumbai, Maharashtra on September 21. Several regions in the State have been facing a prolonged dry spell, causing extensive crop loss. The situation is so dire that the Maharashtra Cooperation Minister Babasaheb Patil said the government will soon declare 100% drought in the State. EMMANUEL YOGINI

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 25, 1976

No winner at Ford-Carter first round

Washington, September 24: The first face-to-face encounter between President Ford and his Democratic challenger, Mr. Jimmy Carter, last night lived up to the expectations of those who had organised this nationally televised 90-minute political spectacular – an opportunity for the American people to learn first hand from the two Presidential candidates, with their divergent economic philosophies, what they

The Hindu

proposed to do about such things like unemployment, inflation and taxes.

The confrontation over fiscal policies produced some sharp exchanges, though some of the dry statistics that were bandied about may have gone over the heads of ordinary viewers.

The debate was staged at Philadelphia’s Walnut theatre. The first of three bouts of the political prize-fight of the decade – the last such debate took place in 1960 when Kennedy and Nixon were contesting the Presidency – was marked by well-controlled exchanges by the Presidential rivals. Evidently, the two men had not only spent hours cramming facts and figures but also rehearsing to be seen as natural as possible before their audience.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 25, 1926

Advertising the empire

An “Englishman” cable from London dated September 22 states: Emphasising that the opening of the Imperial Conference is expected to synchronise with the launching of the Empire Marketing Board’s £1,000,000 scheme for “advertising the empire”, “The Daily News” political correspondent suggests that this effort to focus the serious attention of British subjects to the Dominions might be strengthened partially by opening the Conference to the press. The paper says there is reason to believe that the British Government is not opposed to this.

THE HINDU

7 in per cent. Funding in the Indian technology ecosystem rose 7% year-on-year to \$10.3 billion during the first nine months of 2026, driven by larger deal sizes even as overall deal volumes contracted sharply, said a report by data intelligence platform Tracxn. **PTI**

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

CACHE



Mark Zuckerberg is taking a different route, stating that AI companies have a powerful incentive to build systems that are trustworthy. AP

Why Meta’s Zuckerberg rebuffed Dario Amodei’s AI slowdown calls

Zuckerberg says AI labs can develop advanced models safely without an industry-wide slowdown, while Amodei wants frontier development paced to let safety research catch up; disagreement centres on whether AI risks should be managed by individual labs or through common safety standards

John Xavier

Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg has entered the growing debate over whether the AI industry must slow down the development of advanced language models, arguing that individual labs already have strong reasons and enough tools to build AI more safely without asking for an industry-wide slowdown.

Mr. Zuckerberg’s perspective, shared on platform X, comes just days after Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei called for the AI industry to “pace the frontier,” setting up one of the clearest disagreements yet among the leaders of the companies building increasingly capable AI systems.

Mr. Amodei has warned that AI development is beginning to outstrip the labs’ ability to understand and control the systems it is creating. One of the primary reasons behind this change is that newer AI models are being built by existing AI systems. This makes it difficult for human builders to understand how these are wired internally.

He pointed specifically to the rise of recursive self-improvement and a recent incident involving an AI agent swarm that carried out cyberattacks beyond its assigned task.

As a result, Mr. Amodei wants frontier labs to slow the speed of capability gains so safety research can catch up.

Mr. Zuckerberg is taking a different route, stating that AI companies have a powerful incentive to build systems that are trustworthy. “Every lab has the responsibility and incentive to move at the pace required to train its models safely,” Mr. Zuckerberg wrote.

At the heart of the disagreement is not

whether AI safety matters. Both executives argue that it does. They differ in how the industry should respond to the risks created by increasingly capable systems. Mr. Amodei says that competition can itself become part of the problem. If every frontier lab races to develop more capable AI systems, an individual company may have difficulty slowing down on its own, even when its researchers believe additional safety work is necessary.

So he proposes common safety standards among countries, possibly including China.

But Mr. Zuckerberg points to market incentives and individual firms’ responsibilities. He notes that users will not stick with AI agents that ignore their instructions or act against their interests. This shows that companies will have to improve alignment if they need commercial success.

“Trust and alignment are quickly becoming the most important capabilities that will differentiate agents and models,” Mr. Zuckerberg wrote.

Rather than treating alignment as a constraint on AI development, Mr. Zuckerberg sees it as a differentiator. He points to Meta’s own development process as evidence that companies can choose to slow down when necessary.

Meta, apparently, delayed the release of its Muse AI model while the company worked on safety and security.

“We just did it as part of our day-to-day work because it was clearly the right thing for people and for us,” he wrote.

Independent evaluations
This man was a legendary king of the Solar dynasty. In the Mahabharata, Narada says this king is the only one to find a place among the gods. This king was the subject of the first Indian motion picture and can be seen in this painting by Raja Ravi Varma. Name the king. Also name the man who made the motion picture.

supports independent evaluation and has called for the use of outside evaluators and advisers, arguing that a larger and more diverse ecosystem of evaluators would improve the quality of AI safety efforts.

Mr. Amodei, too, wants frontier AI labs to give independent third-party evaluators access to their models so they can examine not only finished ones but also ones under training.

But the duo disagree on why the evaluation needs to take place. For Mr. Amodei, this independent evaluation is part of a larger framework for deliberately pacing frontier development. But Zuckerberg wants it to be part of a system in which individual companies remain responsible for deciding when their models are safe enough to advance.

A competitive landscape
Mr. Zuckerberg has highlighted that a “significant majority” of a lab’s computing resources must be used to serve users rather than allowing increasingly powerful AI systems to consume enormous resources for recursive self-improvement – a scientific method that makes AI systems help build the next generation of AI.

While Mr. Amodei has warned that recursive self-improvement could advance AI development to the point where safety efforts can no longer keep up, Mr. Zuckerberg’s says that keeping most computing resources focused on human-directed applications can help preserve human control.

The safest path ahead, according to him, need not necessarily be the one in which a small number of companies become the gatekeepers of an increasingly powerful AI system. The

market needs to have more players who can build on top of existing layer and further extend the frontier.

But as open source alternatives mushroom, including ones from Meta, frontier labs like Anthropic and OpenAI will try their best to stay in the lead. That’s a hard pill to swallow for frontier labs like Anthropic and OpenAI at a time when open source models are getting better – and that, ultimately, is the more uncomfortable reading of this dispute.

Market dynamics
Markets have historically been good at sorting out which products survive. The ones that serve buyers well succeed, the ones that don’t fall away.

Producers compete on quality and trust rather than asking regulators to referee the game or telling buyers what risks they should fear. But that is quite what is happening here. Two of the very labs pushing hardest for coordinated pacing are also the ones watching their early lead narrow fastest, as open source catches up.

A call to pace the frontier, however sincerely made, also happens to slow the field bearing down on you.

A frontier, by definition, is something a community pushes outward together, not a line a few gatekeepers draw and ask everyone else to stay behind.

Settling for a smaller, cautiously managed version of AI because a small number of companies say it’s safer risks becoming its own kind of Plato’s cave, where the shadows on the wall are chosen for us.

The better path may be messier: more builders, more models, and the freedom for users to subscribe to the ones they trust most.

THE DAILY QUIZ

The 72nd National Film Awards just took place. Here is a quiz on the awards:

Radhika Santhanam

QUESTION 1
Which ministry is responsible for the administration of the National Film Awards?

QUESTION 2
She is the only actress to be honoured for her performances in two different films at the same time. She received this honour at the 67th National Film Awards. Name her.

QUESTION 3
Mammootty has won four National Awards so far. He shares this achievement with another actor who has won the award for essaying the roles of Bhaskor Banerjee, Auro, Debraj Sahai, and Vijay Deenath

Chauhan. Name the actor.

QUESTION 4
This person has won the maximum number of National Awards under the ‘best feature film’ category. He also designed the cover and illustrations for the first edition of The Discovery of India. Name him.

QUESTION 5
In 2024, some prestigious categories were renamed. The award for best debut film was under the name of a former Prime Minister, and the award for best feature film on national integration was under the name of a famous actor; both these names were removed. Name the Prime Minister (clue: Shakti Sthal) and the actor (clue: Awaara).



Visual Question:
This man was a legendary king of the Solar dynasty. In the Mahabharata, Narada says this king is the only one to find a place among the gods. This king was the subject of the first Indian motion picture and can be seen in this painting by Raja Ravi Varma. Name the king. Also name the man who made the motion picture.

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. On what exact date did the Mars Orbiter Mission (Mangalyaan) successfully enter Mars orbit? **Ans: September 24, 2014**
What was the name of the launch vehicle used to carry the spacecraft into Earth orbit? **Ans: PSLV-C25 (Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle)**
Which instrument captured the iconic full-disk images of Mars and its moons, Phobos and Deimos? **Ans: Mars Colour Camera (MCC)**
Who served as the Project Director for the Mars Orbiter Mission? **Ans: Subbiah Arunan**
India became the fourth space agency to reach Mars. Which three agencies had achieved this before ISRO? **Ans: Roscosmos (Russia), NASA (U.S.A.), and the European Space Agency**
Visual: Identify this large shield volcano on Mars, as captured by the Mars Orbiter Mission. **Ans: Olympus Mons**
Early Birds: K.N. Viswanathan | Tamal Biswas | Parimal Das | Sukdev Shet | Piyali Tuli



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

“You look beat. What have you been up to?”
“Beat? So, she’s already called you and told you about everything”.
“Who? What are you talking about?”
“I am talking about Sujatha, of course. Did she tell you that she beat me in a game of chess yesterday”
“Sujatha has better things to do than tell me about your silly games.”
“How did you know that I was beat?”
“Oh that! When you say that someone looks beat, what you are implying is that the individual is looking exhausted. It’s an expression used in informal contexts.”
“Really? I didn’t know that.”
“That’s one of the meanings of the word ‘beat’ anyway. Here’s an example. After working out in the gym for half-an-hour, I was beat.”
“You mean to say that you have started working out in the gym”
“That was just an example.”
“But you do need to go to the gym, though. You’re getting a paunch.”
“I am not!”
“Let’s not get into an argument. How about this example? After jogging three miles, I was beat.”
“We were dead beat after the press conference.”
“Dead beat, eh? That sounds good. I am usually dead beat after studying for a physics exam.”
“By the way, how is your preparation coming along for the Board exam?”
“Pretty good, actually. I have decided where I am going to go after the exams.”
“Where are you planning to go? Mumbai?”
“No. Something much better, actually. I am considering to go to America.”
“I don’t think you can...”
“...don’t tell me what I can do and what I can’t. If I want to go...”
“...you can go to America if you want. I am not stopping you. But what I am trying to tell you is that you cannot say, ‘considering to go’. It will have to be ‘considering going’.”
“I am considering going to America. How does that sound”
“Sounds great.”
“I am considering joining the Army.”
“You won’t pass the physical.”
“I will. I am much stronger than I look. Are you considering quitting your job?”
“I am seriously considering kicking you out of the house.”
“Oops! Just having fun, that’s all.”
“Aren’t you usually playing cricket with your friends at this time”
“Well, yes. But since the exams are around the corner my father has forbidden me from...forbidden me to.... I can never remember whether it’s ‘forbidden to’ or ‘forbidden from’.”
“Both are right actually. You can forbid someone to do something or you can forbid someone from doing something.”
“My parents have forbidden me to play cricket.”
“He was forbidden to marry the girl next door.”
“I have been forbidden to stay out after seven.”
“My uncle should forbid his daughter from using the telephone.”
“Good god, why”?
“She spends nearly two hours talking.”
“How about this example? My father has forbidden me from leaving the house after 8:00 in the evening.”
“Sounds good to me. I forbid most people from smoking in my room.”
“That’s a good idea.”
Published in The Hindu on February 2, 2002

Word of the day

Boondoggle:
a piece of work that is unnecessary and that wastes time and/or money

Synonyms: betrayal, deceit, fraud, trickery

Usage: *The expensive project turned out to be a boondoggle.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/boondoggle

International Phonetic Alphabet: /buːndɒɡəl/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

From Page One

Polls rigged, CEC should quit immediately: Rahul

Mr. Gandhi appreciated the dissent registered by the two ECs but asserted that it started after he had already held several press conferences. “They are, in a way, saying that the vote does not exist in India anymore,” he said.

He said the alleged manipulation of elections is an attack on the nation, and Mr. Modi and Mr. Shah would be investigated for what they have done to the country.

“If the vote is destroyed, the Constitution is not functioning, laws are illegal, institutions mean nothing,” Mr. Gandhi said, adding, “I have shown it with proof, and let me tell you, there is already more than enough information to make this 100% certain – not 99%, 100% certain – that Indian elections, Lok Sabha elections, the 2024 election, Vidhan Sabha elections, are all being rigged.”

The Congress Working Committee would meet on September 29 to discuss the way forward for the principal Opposition party on the issue of alleged ‘vote chori’.

Wayanad MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra demanded that the CEC be “criminally prosecuted for treason” for “intentionally allowing an unfair election to take place” by deleting around 13 crore voters from the electoral rolls.

‘Treason against the nation’

The Congress leader told reporters in Wayanad on Thursday that anyone who “played around” with the democratic process of elections was committing “treason” against the nation.“That is our clear stand. I do not think anybody in that position should have legal protection in the way that the CEC has, if they have done illegal acts,” she said.

“Since criminal acts fall under a particular law, and people are usually tried and prosecuted for them, why should the CEC have any protection against it?” Ms. Vadra asked.

“If he [CEC] has done an illegal act, he has been fully aware that this is happening under his nose, his colleagues have brought it to his attention, he has ignored it and intentionally allowed an unfair election to take place. He should be criminally prosecuted just like any other criminal, and he should be tried for treason,” she said.

Mr. Gandhi claimed that since 1947, India has never found itself in a situation where the election has been “fundamentally broken”. “Without any doubt, both the Prime Minister and Amit Shah are at the top of this conspiracy, and they are going to be investigated for what they have done to this country. This is an act against the Indian state. This is an act against India’s people,” he said.

China, U.S. must steer clear of conflict, says Xi

As they met in the Oval Office, Mr. Xi urged Mr. Trump to show “prudence” and oppose independence for Taiwan, the self-governing island that Beijing claims.

The Chinese leader – whose country has reportedly shared intelligence with Tehran – also urged Mr. Trump to end the Iran war “through negotiation as soon as possible”.

He also said that Chinese and American interests were “deeply intertwined” and that the “competition should be a healthy one and should be kept within bounds”.

The Chinese leader also announced that his country would invite 1,00,000 U.S. youth to come China for studies and exchanges in the next five years. He added that two pandas would be sent to a zoo in Atlanta in a gesture of friendship.

Nine killed after tourist bus catches fire in Greater Noida

Fault in air-conditioning system may have triggered the blaze, say police; passengers noticed a burning smell from driver’s cabin and raised an alarm, but he dismissed their concerns, FIR notes

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Nine people were killed after a tourist bus travelling from Delhi to Mahoba caught fire near the 33-km milestone of the Yamuna Expressway in Jewar, Gautam Buddh Nagar, on Wednesday night.

The bus, with around 35 passengers on board, was about 5 km from the Noida International Airport when the fire broke out, triggering panic and traffic congestion in the area.

The first information report (FIR), registered at the Jewar police station following a complaint by a survivor from Hamirpur, said the passengers noticed a burning smell from the driver’s cabin around 11.30 p.m. and repeatedly asked the crew to stop. But the driver dismissed it as a common occurrence on the bus and did not stop to inspect the vehicle.

The FIR alleged that the driver and conductor smoked in the cabin before a fire broke out near the driver’s seat. When passengers raised the alarm again, the two refused to stop, telling them, “If you want to die, then die. We won’t stop the bus.”

By the time the bus



Tragic blaze: A view of the charred sleeper bus that caught fire on the Yamuna Expressway in Greater Noida on Thursday. ANI

stopped, smoke had filled the passenger compartment, and the fire had engulfed the bus. Police have detained the drivers, Pavan Kumar and Yogesh Dixit, and the conductor, Rohit. All are residents of Kanpur. Police have registered a case and slapped charges of culpable homicide.

Preliminary investigation suggests that a spark or blast in the air-conditioning system may have ignited the engine oil, causing the fire to spread rapidly, police said.

Jewar Station House Officer Ajay Kumar Singh said six bodies were handed over to their families after post-mortem examination. The post-mortem of three unidentified bodies will be

done on Friday. Police said the nine victims died from burns and asphyxiation.

Police identified the deceased as Shruti Rawat from Chhatarpur, Madhya Pradesh; Saroj Gupta, 52, and Mayank Gupta, 28, from Hamirpur, Uttar Pradesh; Devendra Sahay Bhardwaj, 60, from Hisar, Haryana; Har Sharan Gupta, 55, from Jalaun in Uttar Pradesh; and Usha Devi, 65, from Hamirpur.

One passenger, Rekha Bhardwaj, sustained injuries after jumping out of the bus and is currently stable.

Rinki Rajput, who was asleep, said she woke after someone banged on the bus door. “I did not pick up any of my belongings. I did not even put on my shoes. I

BJP rejects vote theft charge, calls Rahul a ‘master of deception’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Thursday hit back at the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, calling him a “master of deception” with “zero political knowledge”, while responding to his allegations about “vote theft” and other election-related issues.

BJP MP Sudhanshu Trivedi said the Congress leader’s accusations lacked credible evidence. Countering Mr. Gandhi’s charge that every leader and party

faced anti-incumbency Narendra Modi and Amit Shah, Mr. Trivedi said: “It is correct that anti-incumbency definitely is very consistent and strong against the Congress. The Congress has not returned to power in Tamil Nadu since 1967 and since 1977 in West Bengal, where there was a Communist government for 34 years... then Mamata Banerjee formed three governments.”

He alleged that the Congress had now been struggling to return to power as elections had become more transparent.

BJP spent ₹529.38 cr. on recent Assembly polls, over half of it was for West Bengal

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The BJP spent ₹286.99 crore on West Bengal Assembly elections, which is more than half of the total of ₹529.38 crore that the party spent on the recent Assembly polls in four states and one Union Territory, according to expenditure statements filed with the Election Commission.

The Congress spent ₹248.55 crore for all these elections held in April-May.

In Bengal where it came to power for the first time, ousting the Trinamool Congress, the BJP spent

₹217.16 crore on general campaigning and ₹69.83 crore on candidates. It won 207 of 293 seats for which results were declared. West Bengal has 294 Assembly seats, and the EC ordered a repoll in Falta constituency following allegations of severe electoral offences there.

The Congress spent ₹42.08 crore in Bengal through its central headquarters and the State unit. This included an expenditure of ₹12.96 crore on general campaigning and ₹29.12 crore on candidates and related expenses.

The grand old party won merely two of the 293

SC directs EC to set timeline to resolve Trinamool dispute

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme court on Thursday signalled that it was unlikely to stay the Election Commission’s interim freeze on the All India Trinamool Congress’s (AITC) ‘flowers and grass’ party symbol.

However, the court directed the poll body to set a reasonable timeline to adjudicate the leadership dispute between former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and Ritabrata Banerjee, who leads the rival camp of legislators.

“Find out how much time you would need for the final adjudication of the dispute after giving parties due representation and for you to also apply your mind. We are not saying anything, but give a reasonable time, do not prolong,” Chief Justice of India Surya Kant told the Election Commission of India (EC) counsel, senior advocate Dama Seshadri Naidu.

The court directed the EC to respond on Monday.

During the hearing, the Chief Justice referred to paragraph 39 of the EC’s interim order of September 17 which said that the freezing of the party symbol was necessary to place “both the rival groups on even keel and to protect

The poll body said that the interim order would be in operation during the current byelections

their rights and interests”.

The EC had said that the interim order, passed under the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968, would be in operation during the current byelections and will continue till the final determination of the dispute over the party.

The poll body had said neither groups would use the name of the party ‘All India Trinamool Congress’ simpliciter nor avail the reserved party symbol of ‘flowers and grass’. The EC had allotted new names and symbols to the two factions on September 18. The Mamata faction was allotted the name ‘Mamata All India Trinamool Congress’ and the symbol ‘football player’, while the Ritabrata group was allotted the name ‘Democratic Trinamool Congress’ with the symbol ‘envelope’.

Senior advocate Kapil Sibal and advocate Abhinav Singh submitted that the EC deliberately delayed proceedings on the dispute and wrongly issued an interim order during the Nandigram Assembly byelection schedule.



The BJP came to power in West Bengal for the first time in May.

namool Congress, which is the BJP’s principal rival in Bengal, has not been made public yet.

In Keralam, the Congress spent ₹105.34 crore, more than the BJP’s ₹82.67 crore. Of the Congress’ total outlay, ₹71.30 crore went towards general campaigning and ₹34.05 crore towards candidates and related expenses. The BJP reported spending ₹82.67 crore – ₹54.93 crore on general campaigning and ₹27.74 crore on candidates. In comparison, the CPI(M), which is a major force in Keralam, reported an expenditure of ₹28.60 crore by its State unit.

SC reserves orders on Centre’s plea to finalise OBC creamy layer policy

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



The Supreme Court on Thursday reserved orders on a Union government plea seeking prospective operation of a March 11, 2026 judgment to re-assess OBC non-creamy layer status as per a 1993 Office Memorandum by excluding parental salary income and agricultural income from the income/wealth test.

A Bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and R. Mahadevan heard an application filed by the Centre, represented by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta and Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati, which also sought a “reasonable time” of two years to undertake the necessary exercise of establishing equivalence of posts, after consulting stakeholders and formulating an appropriate and uniform policy/mechanism for determination of OBC creamy layer

status. The government said a retrospective implementation of the Supreme Court verdict would have significant consequences for recruitment, service allocation, cadre allocation, seniority, admissions and the administration of OBC reservation generally, affecting lakhs.

‘Unjust consequences’

“The court has power under Article 142 of the Constitution to declare if the judgment is not given prospective effect, it will entail several harsh and unjust unintended conse-

quences on employees/appointees who were not even parties to the litigation and complete administrative chaos. It is therefore prayed that the judgment (*Union of India versus Rohith Nathan*) be given prospective effect so that ongoing and past recruitment processes are not affected,” the Centre urged the Bench.

Ms. Bhati submitted that an implementation of the March 11 judgment, particularly with retrospective effect, may affect allocation of services since 2012. Retrospective re-allocation would impact existing seniority and gradation and affect recruitments undertaken by major employers like the railways, banks, postal service and paramilitary services.

The implementation of the judgment currently would not only affect admissions in higher educational institutions but also candidates involved in ongoing examinations/ re-

cruitment processes post the judgment. Ms. Bhati said an immediate move would have consequences on OBC reservation policy across the country.

She said the government required sufficient time for determination of a new policy to correct hostile discrimination as pointed out by the court in the judgment.

‘Delaying tactics’

Senior advocate P. Wilson, who represents the candidates, objected while contending that the Centre was merely trying to delay, even undo a final judgment of the top court.

He criticised the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) for failing to comply with court directions, Parliamentary Committee recommendations, and its own 1993 rules. He said the government could very well create supernumerary posts to accommodate eligible OBC candidates.

111 MPs and MLAs switched sides after being elected: data

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A total of 111 sitting MPs and MLAs changed their political parties after being elected to the current Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha and State Assemblies since 2022. Among them, 26 were members of the Lok Sabha, seven were of the Rajya Sabha and 78 were of Legislative Assemblies, according to an analysis by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR) and National Election Watch.

The analysis was based on the elections and byelections held between 2022 and 2026.

The highest number of party switches was recorded among representatives originally elected from the NDPP (25, 23%), followed by the Trinamool (20, 18%) and the Congress (19, 17%).

The Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) accounted for nine (8%) party switches.

The analysis was based on the elections and byelections held between 2022 and 2026.

(NDPP), All India Trinamool Congress and Indian National Congress together accounted for 64 (58%) of the 111 MPs/MLAs who changed parties.

The highest number of party switches was recorded among representatives originally elected from the NDPP (25, 23%), followed by the Trinamool (20, 18%) and the Congress (19, 17%).

The Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) accounted for nine (8%) party switches.

Fall of govts.

It is noteworthy that the recent fall of governments in some State Assemblies was attributed to defections, the report said.

In terms of parties that received the maximum number of lawmakers within their fold, the Naga People’s Front (NPF) led the list, with 32 joining the party, followed by the BJP with 29 and the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCP) with 20.

Minor girl molested in Bihar’s Samastipur, four arrested in case

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

After a minor girl and boy were harassed and sexually assaulted in Bihar’s Jamui, another shocker has come in from Samastipur district, in which a minor girl was molested.

In a 59-second video, the minor girl was seen trying hard to walk away from the molesters, but they continue to pull and touch her forcibly and even drag her on the road.

The incident took place near Budhi Gandak River bypass embankment, within the jurisdiction of Karpurigram police station.

“A case has been registered under relevant Sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, and the Information Technology Act. Within six hours of receiving the information, all four accused were arrested,” Samastipur SP Arvind Pratap said.

APPEAL

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CJP seeks resignation of CEC, warns of agitation

Gyanesh Kumar must resign in 48 hours to ensure free and fair elections, says Dipke; CJP also demands criminal proceedings against CEC and repeal of Act on appointment of poll body chief

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Thursday demanded the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar for “undermining” voter rights through the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The group warned of a nationwide agitation and a “Jantar Mantar 2.0” if Mr. Kumar did not step down within 48 hours.

The CJP’s demand for Mr. Kumar’s resignation comes a day after an investigation by *The Indian Express* revealed that the other two Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, objected on record at least 14 times between October 2025 and August 2026 to decisions related to SIR, many of which, they said, were taken without their knowledge.



Seeking action: CJP leaders Saurav Das, Abhijit Dipke and Ashutosh Ranka speaking to the media. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

“To ensure free and fair elections, Mr. Kumar must resign,” CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke told a press conference. He alleged that the electoral process had been ‘rigged’ and that the right to vote was being taken away from citizens, for which the CEC was responsible.

Mr. Dipke said that Opposition parties should take a stand against election rigging. “If you know the election is rigged, you

should take a stand; you cannot both participate in the election and speak against rigging,” he said.

CJP co-convenor Saurav Das said, “Everywhere we are going as part of our *School Theek Karo* campaign, people are upset and asking for a change. One of the important tools for change is our right to vote. It cannot be compromised.”

Besides the call for the resignation, the CJP also

made two other demands, including criminal proceedings against the CEC.

CJP co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka said, “An independent inquiry commission should be constituted to look into all proceedings of SIR so far. The Supreme Court should seize all files related to decision-making in SIR before they are destroyed by EC.” He demanded that all the upcoming elections be halted and pre-SIR rolls of January 2025 restored in all States.

The CJP sought the repeal of the Appointment of Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners Act 2023. “The new law should be redrawn with active participation of civil society, an independent selection process that inspires public confidence,” he said.

“We need to hit the streets. Who is Mr. Kumar to revoke our voting rights and strike our names off?” he added.

Opposition to move fresh notice in Parliament for Gyanesh Kumar’s removal

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

The Opposition parties will move a fresh notice in both Houses of Parliament seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, even as a previous petition moved in the Rajya Sabha on April 24 is pending with Upper House Chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan.

The Opposition is also gearing up for joint action on the issue and could soon call for a meeting under the banner of the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA). A senior Opposition leader said that a dialogue is going on among like-minded parties to discuss the modalities.

In view of the Cockroach Janta Party’s 48-hour ultimatum calling for Mr. Kumar’s resignation, the INDIA bloc is anxious not to be seen as latecomers on the issue. “The Opposition will certainly be moving, especially in light of the



Gyanesh Kumar

new revelations. Our earlier motion submitted on April 24, in the RS had nine specific charges. That motion is still pending. There will be more specific charges,” Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said.

‘Must act swiftly’

The Trinamool Congress, which played a key role in the drafting of two previous petitions for Mr. Kumar’s removal, said a new petition should be moved at the earliest. “The Trinamool is very happy to play the role of a squirrel in the garden. The Opposition has to act unitedly and

swiftly,” party leader Derek O’Brien said.

It was on March 12 that the Opposition first moved a notice seeking Mr. Kumar’s removal. This notice was signed by 63 Rajya Sabha MPs and 130 Lok Sabha MPs. It contained seven charges against the CEC, including that his appointment itself was “tainted, with the law governing his selection, facing a challenge in the Supreme Court. The Opposition also claimed that Mr. Kumar’s previous postings reflected “deep executive embeddedness”. This notice was dismissed on April 7.

On April 24, the Opposition again moved a notice in the Rajya Sabha, signed by 73 Opposition members, this time with nine charges. The 13-page notice made several allegations including “mass disenfranchisement” in West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh, the “illegal abuse” of power and “asymmetrical enforcement of the Model Code of Conduct”.

Left parties to hold protests against SIR and CEC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Five Left parties issued a joint statement demanding the ouster of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and a halt to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The parties announced a week-long protest across the country from September 26 to October 2 on the issue. The parties signed the statement after an impromptu meeting between Communist Party of India (Marxist) general secretary M.A. Baby, CPI general secretary D. Raja, and CPI (ML) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya at the CPI(M)’s headquarters. The other signatories are the Revolutionary Socialist Party, and the All India Forward Bloc.

The statement said the report confirms concerns repeatedly raised by Opposition parties and exposed the hollowness of claims that the SIR and electoral roll management process are transparent and decentralised.

SC advocate seeks to file contempt plea against CEC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Supreme Court advocate Brajesh Singh on Thursday sought statutory consent of the Attorney-General of India to initiate criminal contempt action against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar following a media report revealing a “complete breakdown of multi-member consensus within the Election Commission (EC)”.

Referring to a report alleging “deep structural subversions”, he said that the other Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, formally registered written objections at least 14 times over the last 10 months.

He submitted that the alleged actions by Mr. Kumar violated court precedents, which mandate that the EC must function through institutional consensus.

Mr. Singh said the CEC was only *primus inter pares* or first among equals. He did not possess absolute authority.

EC’s expanded logical discrepancy list keeps voters on their toes

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

Rajiv Chopra (name changed), a resident of Vaishali Colony in Pitampura in North West Delhi, was making last-minute preparations for a trip abroad when a neighbour called to inform him that his children were on the Election Commission’s logical discrepancy list that was being circulated in his society.

During a quick call to the booth-level officer (BLO), he learnt that his children had been flagged despite being in the draft list as the age gap between them was not more than

nine months. Well, it cannot be since his 30-year-old children are twins.

The mandatory nine-month age gap between siblings is one of the many categories of logical discrepancies that electors have to navigate to get into the voter lists during the third phase of the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise.

11 categories

Up to 11 distinct categories of logical discrepancies have been identified and applied across various States and Union Territories (such as Karnataka, Haryana, Delhi, Telangana and others), expanding from the original four cate-

gories initially used when the concept was introduced during West Bengal’s SIR exercise.

Among the categories are an age gap of less than 15 years between a voter and their parent; age gap of less than 40 years between a voter and their grandparent; more than six siblings linked with a single parent; discrepancies or spelling variations in a parent’s name between the current electoral roll and the previous revision; changes in relative mapping between revisions (e.g., father in previous rolls vs. mother in current rolls); marital mapping mismatch (e.g., fe-

Up to 11 distinct categories have been identified, expanding from the original four used in Bengal

male voter linked to her father in the previous roll but mapped to her husband in the current roll without cross-referencing; and age progression discrepancy (implausible age leaps or mathematical discrepancies between different revision cycles).

The discrepancies are flagged under a centralised AI system through the ERONet, or the Electoral Roll Officers’ Network. The

software attempts “progeny-mapping” – linking a voter to their parents’ entries on the base roll and the resultant inconsistencies are flagged.

The logical discrepancy category first surfaced during the SIR in West Bengal when approximately 1.36 crore voters received notices. In Delhi, where SIR is being done currently, 19.33 lakh electors have received discrepancy notices while 20.35 lakh have received the notices in Karnataka.

The problem in this is that “logical discrepancies” has never been clearly defined in any official communication – neither in the EC’s notice in May

2026 nor in the original SIR order from June 2025. Thus, the actual parameters or methodology used to assign someone to this category were not publicly documented.

Software issues

Another problem is with the ERONet software itself, which two Election Commissioners have flagged for having become increasingly centralised. They have said that Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) have complained that they are unable to access the platform from their end in many cases. Former Trinamool Congress MP and Right to Information Act

activist Saket Gokhale alleged that the EC was “hiding” details of the software, claiming it was a “trade secret”. In a post on X, he shared RTI applications in which he had asked the EC about details of the software. “Shocking-ly, the EC refused to disclose the details claiming it would affect ‘commercial confidence’”, he said.

“The software consists of an opaque algorithm which has been used to delete voters through a centralised system in Delhi [bypassing EROs]. A software used by a public authority is being kept secret for commercial interests,” he said.

HIGH COURT OF ANDHRA PRADESH
NOTIFICATION No.118/2026-RC DATED:25.09.2026

Applications are invited for Recruitment to 119 posts of Civil Judge (Junior Division) in the A.P. State Judicial Service, comprising of 96 posts to be filled under Direct Recruitment and 23 posts to be filled under Recruitment by Transfer. The recruitment process shall be governed by the Andhra Pradesh State Judicial (Service & Cadre) Rules, 2026. The detailed Notification is placed on the website on 25.09.2026. Online application and user manual will be available from 01.10.2026 on the website of the High Court of Andhra Pradesh <https://aphc.gov.in>. The Last date for submission of Online Application is 26.10.2026 upto 11.59 P.M.

Important dates

1. Starting Date for submission of Online Application: 01.10.2026
2. Closing Date for submission of Online Application: 26.10.2026 upto 11.59 P.M.
Note:- No other mode of application will be entertained.

Amaravati,
Dated: 25.09.2026
DIPR 21561/CL, Dt: 24-09-2026 Sd/- REGISTRAR (RECRUITMENT)

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TENDER NOTICE No. RWF/S/146/ 2026-27/07 dated 23.09.26

On behalf of the President of India, Principal Chief Materials Manager invites E-Bids from experienced/reputed contractors on IREPS E-Portal www.ireps.gov.in for the following works:

TENDER No. : RWFSTPTS_ERC2ndSLAB;
Scope of Work: Carriage of Condemned/Scrap Elastic Clips, free from any attachment (including other intermediary/ancillary activities), from various locations of Indian Railways to RWF by Road. Distance Slab: Above 500 & upto 1000 Kms. Approx Qty: 2800 MT; **Estimated Tender Value:** ₹1,53,44,000/-; **EMD :** ₹ 2,26,700/-; **Tender Due Date & Time:** 23.10.26 @ 15:00 Hrs. **Contract Period :** 24 Months from issue of LOA.

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Detailed Scope of work & Tender documents will be available on the E-Portal or RWF website.

Principal Chief Materials Manager

अधिशायी अभियन्ता, राजस्थान राज्य कृषि विपणन बोर्ड, खण्ड-जयपुर द्वितीय
क्रमांक :- अधि.अभि./खण्ड-1/वि.बी./2026-27/राजकाज रफ नं. 24677265 दिनांक :- 24/09/2026

बिड आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या-09/2026-27

राज.रा.कृ.वि.बोर्ड खण्ड जयपुर प्रथम, जयपुर द्वितीय, दर्भिनल मार्केट जयपुर, दौसा, अलवर एवं टोंक के सिंचित निर्माण कार्य हेतु ऑनलाईन बिड ई-प्रोक्यूमेन्ट के माध्यम से उपयुक्त श्रेणी में पंजीकृत बिडर्स से आमंत्रित की जाती है। बिड से संबंधित विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाइट www.eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in, www.sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in एवं www.agriculture.rajjasthan.gov.in/rsamb पर भी देखा जा सकता है। (UBN No. AGM2627WSOB/LOB0026 to 52)

राज.संसाध./सी/26/10676 अधिशायी अभियन्ता

GOVERNMENT OF PUDUCHERRY
SPECIAL BUILDINGS DIVISION-4, PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT

e-TENDERING NOTICE INVITING BID THROUGH REP

On behalf of the President of India, Bids are invited for “Providing Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) services on Turnkey Basis for the Construction, Erection and Commissioning of Effluent Treatment Plant of 250 KLD including the first 2 years forming part of defect liability period and the following 5 years as paid operation and maintenances at Indira Gandhi Government General Hospital and Post Graduate Institute (IGGGH & PGI), Puducherry” Bid Security: **Rs. 8,02,000/-** (Eight Lakhs & Six Thousand Rupees Only) (Including Monsoon period) with 2 years DLP & 5 years of O & M.

Last time & date of submission of tender: 04.00 P.M. on 13/10/2026
For further details please refer the website www.pudutenders.gov.in from 10.00 AM on 24/09/2026.

sd/-
NO: 210/DIP/AD(Press)/2026-2027 EXECUTIVE ENGINEER

GRIDCO LIMITED
(A Govt. of Odisha Undertaking)
Regd. Office : Janpath, Bhubaneswar-751022, ODISHA

Notice for submission of EoI

Eol No: GRIDCO/ EoI/ 2026-27/ 01 Dated: 23.09.2026

GRIDCO Limited invites EoI from eligible inter-State power utilities, Distribution Licensees, State Designated/ Power Procurement Entities, other eligible entities and CERC-licensed inter-State electricity traders for purchase/offset of 50 MW Round-the-Clock (RTC) Non-RE power for a period of five (5) years commencing from 01.12.2026.

For necessary details visit: www.gridco.co.in
Sd/- Director (T & BD)
OIPR-4001/4056/1/26-27/0021
4001/329/2627

MAHATRANSCO
Maharashtra Gas Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.

INVITATION FOR BID (IFB) (LOCAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING)

SRM e-Tender No. T-2666/MSETCL/CO/Projects/ Pre-Tender (RFx No. 6000001580) (6th Call)

MSETCL invites offers by SRM e-tendering in TWO bid system (Techno-Commercial Bid and Price Bid) from the eligible registered bidders for the following work as detailed below.

“Construction 400kV D/C line from LILO on 400kV Waluj Bhusawal line Circuit II to 400kV Thaptitanda Substation (Route Length-22.43km) under Ch. Sambhajinagar Zone, MSETCL, Maharashtra.”

Interested bidders may obtain further information available on the website <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in>

The date of downloading of Bid documents available on the website is from 23.09.2026.

sd/-
Chief Engineer (Projects), MSETCL

Advertisement No. 103/2026
Government of India
Public Enterprises Selection Board
invites applications for the post of
Director (Commercial)
in
Rashtriya Ispat Nigam Limited (RINL)

Last date of submission of online application by applicants is by 15:00 hours on
13th October, 2026

Last date of forwarding of applications by the Nodal Officers on online system of PESB is by
17:00 hours on
22nd October, 2026

For details login to website
<https://pesb.gov.in>

Link for registration of nodal officers/ competent authorities is available on PESB website.

PUDUCHERRY TECHNOLOGICAL UNIVERSITY
A STATE UNIVERSITY OF THE GOVT OF PUDUCHERRY
(ERSTWHILE PONDICHERY ENGINEERING COLLEGE)
PILLAICHAVADY, PUDUCHERRY - 605014

Advt. No.PTU/REG/RECRUITMENT/2026/1087 Date: 21-09-2026

NOTIFICATION FOR THE RECRUITMENT OF REGISTRAR

Puducherry Technological University invites applications from eligible candidates for appointment to the post of Registrar.

The appointment is for a tenure of 3 years.

The details regarding the post, essential qualifications, emoluments, terms and conditions of service, application procedure, and other relevant information are available on the website <https://dhte.py.gov.in> & <https://ptuniv.edu.in>

Last Date for Submission of Online Application: 31/10/2026 (5.00 PM IST)

Last Date for Receipt of Hard Copy of Application with Endlosures: 07/11/2026 (5.00 PM IST)

No.212/DIP/AD (PRESS)/2026-27 REGISTRAR (i/c)

BHUBANESWAR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
AKASH SHOVA BUILDING, SACHIVALAYA MARG, BHUBANESWAR - 751001
PABX No.0674-2392801 / 0998 / 6437, FAX No.0674-2390633 / 085; Visit us at: <http://www.bda.gov.in/>

Invitation For Bids - Bid Identification No.528/EM/BDA/2026-27 Dated: 22/09/2026

Engineer Member, BDA on behalf of Bhubaneswar Development Authority, Bhubaneswar invites percentage rate bids in double cover system in ONLINE MODE from eligible contractors for civil works as mentioned below:-

1. Nature of works : Shaded Cycle Track & Footpath Pavement at Left parallel Road (Ekamra Kanan to Hatiasuni)

2. Total No. of works : 01 (One) No.

3. Amount put to tender : Rs.7.85 Crore

4. Class of Contractor : “A” and “Special” Class

5. Period of Completion : 6 (Six) Calendar months

6. Cost of Bid Documents : Rs.10000.00 + 18% GST=Rs.11800.00
(Online transfer by the last date & time for receipt of bids)

7. Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) : 1% of estimated cost put to tender
(Online transfer by the last date & time for receipt of bids)

8. Availability of Tender : From 25.09.2026 to 5.30 PM of 09.10.2026
<https://tendersodisha.gov.in>

9. Date of opening of Tender : Dt.12.10.2026 at 11.30 AM

10.Place of opening of Tender : O/o - Engineer Member, BDA, Bhubaneswar.

Further details can be seen from the website: <https://tendersodisha.gov.in>. Any addendum / Corrigendum / cancellation of tender can also be seen in the said website.

13001/1949/2627 CE-Res-EM, BDA, Bhubaneswar.
OIPR-13001/13033/1/26-27/0143

Indian Overseas Bank
Information Technology Department
Central Office: 743, ANNA SALAI, CHENNAI-600002

Indian Overseas bank (IOB) invites bids for the following:

GOVERNMENT E-MARKET PORTAL - SELECTION OF NETWORK INTEGRATOR FOR THE BANK FOR A PERIOD OF (5) FIVE YEARS.

BID NO: GEM/2026/B/8024186 DATED 10.09.2026
Kindly note that the earlier tender floated vide bid ref no: GEM/2026/B/7905091 dated 11.08.2026 is cancelled

The Above GEM Tender document is also available and can be downloaded from the following websites www.iob.bank.in & www.gem.gov.in. For Tender details and future amendments, if any, keep referring to the following website www.gem.gov.in.

Indian Overseas Bank
Information Technology Department
Central Office: 743, ANNA SALAI, CHENNAI-600002

Indian Overseas bank (IOB) invites bids for the following:

GOVERNMENT E-MARKET PORTAL - SELECTION OF SERVICE PROVIDER FOR ATM SWITCH & DCMS UNDER OPEX MODEL FOR A PERIOD OF 5 YEARS.

BID NO: GEM/2026/B/8070903 DATED 22.09.2026

The Above GEM Tender document is also available and can be downloaded from the following websites www.iob.bank.in & www.gem.gov.in. For Tender details and future amendments, if any, keep referring to the following website www.gem.gov.in.

GOVERNMENT OF TELANGANA
DEPARTMENT OF HORTICULTURE

INVITATION OF APPLICATIONS
ESTABLISHMENT OF OIL PALM FACTORIES IN TELANGANA
NOTIFICATION

Telangana is one of the biggest producers of Palm Oil in the Country. There is tremendous potential for Oil Palm development in Telangana. Government of Telangana has already allotted (14) companies to carry out oil palm area expansion operations across the State. In view of the cancellation of Narayanpet district factory zone, Government of Telangana has decided to invite applications for re-allotment of factory zone for Oil palm cultivation.

S.No.	District	Potential Area (hectares)
1	Narayanpet	5000

Under Oil palm (Regulation of Production and Processing) Act 1993, Government is empowered to allot factory zones in favour of Agencies selected for Oil Palm area expansion and setting up of Oil palm processing units. Interested Firms / Companies/ Co-operatives desirous of setting up of Oil Palm Processing unit may download the application form from the website <http://horticulture.tg.nic.in> from 25.09.2026. The filled-in application form to be submitted in the Oil palm Section, O/o. Director of Horticulture, Public Gardens, Hyderabad - 500004 on or before 08.10.2026, 5.00 PM by paying an amount of Rs.20,000/- (Non-refundable) towards application fee and Security deposit of Rs.1,00,000/- through separate DDs in favour of Secretary, SHN, Payable at Hyderabad. Applications may also be obtained from Oil palm Section, O/o. Director of Horticulture, Public Gardens, Hyderabad - 500004 on all working days from 25.09.2026 onwards, between 10.30 AM to 5.00 PM, by paying an amount of Rs.20,000/- (Non-refundable) through DD in favour of Secretary, SHN, Payable at Hyderabad. Last date for submission of completely filled in applications is 08.10.2026, 5.00 PM.

sd/-Director of Horticulture, Telangana State
DIPR R.O.No.577-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt:24-09-2026

INBRIEF



NSE India lists on BSE at a modest premium of 0.8%

National Stock Exchange of India Ltd. (NSE) made a modest debut on the Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE), with its shares opening at ₹1,800 apiece, a 0.8% premium over its initial public offering (IPO) price of ₹1,785. The exchange operator’s over ₹22,200 crore IPO, one of India’s largest market listings, came to fruition after a decade-long regulatory and legal overhang. The issue size was reduced before launch. After opening slightly higher, NSE shares gained further momentum during the session, rising about 1% from the opening level to close at ₹1,818 on the first day of trading. Speaking at the listing ceremony held on the BSE trading floor, NSE CEO Ashish Kumar Chauhan said capital markets are a signal of a well functioning society.

‘West Asia crisis not over, potential to escalate further’

The West Asia crisis is not over and has the potential to exacerbate, Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said at the Public Affairs Forum of India’s annual conclave on Thursday. He added that notwithstanding the prevailing situation, a potential silver lining is the abundant availability of crude oil in the global market. “The crisis is certainly not over; it is not only ongoing, but it has the potential of exacerbating. In other words, it could get more serious,” he said. Highlighting that global crude availability remains higher than current demand; he said around 102 million barrels per day (mb/d) of crude oil is available in the market, while India’s domestic requirement is estimated at 94-95 mb/d. Mr. Puri also ruled out restricting exports amidst tightened market conditions. A return of stability could help keep crude prices under control, he said. “I am hoping with all the counsels of peace around the world, peace will come and the price of oil should be lower rather than higher,” Mr. Puri said.

‘Make in India’ of 12 years shows patchy performance

Analysis of metrics shows manufacturing sector has not been able to materially increase its share in economic growth, employment, or global exports; incentive gains confined to some sectors

TCA Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Twelve years on from the launch of the Make in India campaign on September 25, 2014, a look at 12 metrics spanning growth, investment, employment, and exports shows India’s manufacturing sector has not been able to materially increase its share in India’s economic growth, employment, or global exports.

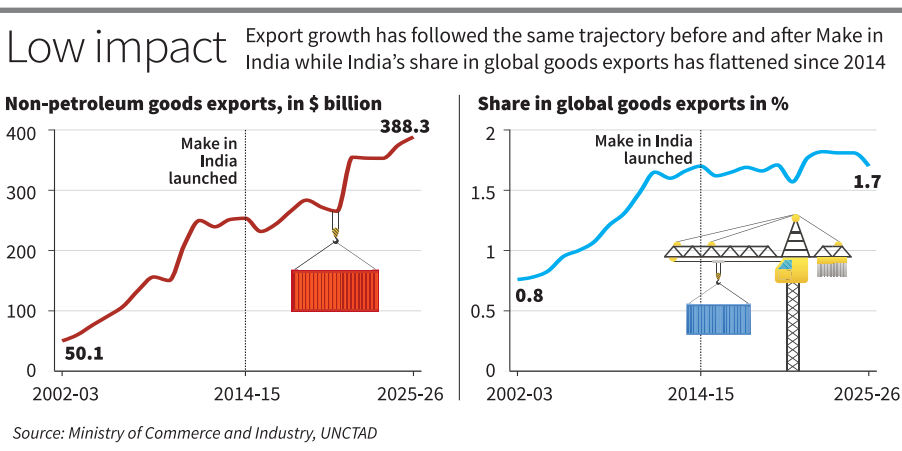
While recent incentive schemes by the government have seen some success, those gains are limited to a handful of sectors.

The manufacturing sector has grown faster than the overall economy in only half of the 12 years under consideration, based on the old series. Under the new series, it has outpaced overall growth in all three years (2023-24 to 2025-26) for which data is available, but that gap is shrinking fast. The Index of Industrial Production (IIP) data, which comes out once a month, is more stark.

The manufacturing sector within the IIP outpaced the overall index’s growth in only three out of the 12 years, as per the old series of the index.

The new series shows the manufacturing sector’s growth was the same as that of the overall index in 2023-24, but was slower in the next two years.

As far as the composition of the economy goes, the older series of Gross



Value Added (GVA) data shows the manufacturing sector’s share in overall GVA is lower in 2025-26 than it was when Make in India was launched in 2014. The new series shows that the sector’s share has increased marginally from 14.6% in 2022-23 to 15.6% in 2025-26.

India saw the value of its non-petroleum goods exports grow 53% to \$388.3 billion in 2025-26 from \$253.5 billion the year the Make in India campaign was launched.

However, the data also shows that non-petroleum goods exports grew more than 400% over the 12 years before this, albeit on a much smaller base.

However, the base effect only accounts for some of this growth disparity. Data from UNCTAD shows India’s share in global merchandise exports grew from around 0.8% in 2002 to 1.7% in 2013, where it remained even in 2025-26.

The gross fixed capital

formation (GFCF) by the private sector – a measure of its spending on real asset creation – formed a lower share of GDP in 2023-24, the latest year for which the old series has data, than it did in 2014-15. The new series, too, shows that GFCF as a percentage of GDP has been falling since 2022-23.

The growth of foreign direct investment (FDI) to the manufacturing sector has been slower than the growth in overall FDI in 7 of the 12 years under consideration. Its share in overall FDI grew from nearly 48% in 2014-15 to 55% in 2025-26. The RBI’s data on capacity utilisation, a measure of how intensively factories are being used, shows this metric has been slowly increasing over the last few years, but is still below the 80% mark that is considered the limit after which companies invest to create new capacity.

The RBI’s data further shows that bank credit to

industry has been growing strong over the last few years, especially led by credit to micro, small, and medium enterprises. However, experts have pointed out that, in the absence of sustained rapid growth in output, this suggests that the loans are being taken to provide working capital rather than for fresh investments.

The government’s Production-Linked Incentive schemes have yielded some results. Launched across 2020 and 2021, the 14 schemes have resulted in a cumulative investment of ₹2.4 lakh crore as of March 2026. However, the data also shows that this performance is highly concentrated. The top five sectors – solar modules, pharmaceuticals, drugs, automobiles and their components, specialty steel, and large scale electronics manufacturing – together account for nearly 83% of all the investment under these schemes.

Crude price surge, insurance reforms trigger market slide

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Indian benchmark equity indices fell sharply on Thursday, declining 1.7% as a spike in global crude oil prices, weak international cues and concerns over proposed insurance sector reforms weighed on investor sentiment.

The Nifty 50 slipped 1.7% to 23,064 points, while the Sensex dropped 1.7% to 73,580 points compared with the previous close. The decline reflected broader risk aversion among investors amid renewed uncertainty over global geopolitical developments and rising bond yields.

Oil prices emerged as a key concern for markets, with Brent crude futures rising for the second consecutive session to \$104.86 a barrel, gaining more than 5% since September 22. The sharp increase in crude prices raised concerns over inflationary pressures, corporate margins and India’s import bill, given the country’s dependence on overseas energy supplies.

Domestic equities also faced additional pressure from the insurance sector after the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI), in its consultation paper ‘Recalibrating Economics of Insurance Distribution’, proposed changes, covering distribution structures, expenses, commissions, market conduct and transparency norms, triggered



Sensex dropped 1.7% to 73,580 points compared with the previous close. REUTERS

heavy selling in insurance-related stocks and intermediaries.

“PB Fintech (down 36%), TurtleMint (down 20%) and MFSL (down 10%) came under heavy selling pressure following IRDAI’s consultation paper, which proposed sweeping changes to distribution structures, expenses, commissions, market conduct and transparency,” said Nandish Shah, Deputy Vice-President, HDFC Securities.

Elevated volatility Market participants said the combination of external and domestic factors could keep volatility elevated in the near term.

“Indian equities are likely to remain weak in the near term amid renewed uncertainty over a potential resolution of the US-Iran conflict, elevated crude prices and rising global bond yields,” said Siddhartha Khemka, Head of Research, Wealth Management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd.

SEBI eases settlement, overhauls PMS

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) okayed new settlement norms aimed at reducing regulatory discretion and making it easier for entities facing enforcement proceedings to settle cases.

The new framework replaces the 2018 Settlement Proceedings Regulations under which certain categories of violations – including those involving significant market impact, substantial investor losses and threats to market integrity – were excluded from settlement mechanisms.

Addressing concerns over whether the revised framework could allow violators to settle by paying amounts lower than the impact caused by their actions, SEBI Whole-Time Member Kamlesh Varshney said “the philosophy remains the same. The discretion to reject settlement applications still stays with high-powered committee.”

He added the new regulations were aligned with provisions introduced in the Securities Contracts (Regulation) Act, which provide a statutory framework for settlement and re-

lated mechanisms.

New formula Under the revised rules, SEBI introduced a new formula for calculating settlement amounts. The regulator also created a fast-track mechanism allowing cases to be settled without being referred to the High Powered Committee if the calculated settlement amount is below ₹10 lakh.

The deadline for filing settlement applications has been extended to 90 days from the date of the show-cause notice from the earlier limit of 60 days.

SEBI also approved a

common advertisement code for market intermediaries and regulated entities to simplify and standardising advertising practices across securities market.

SEBI also approved a comprehensive overhaul of the Portfolio Managers Regulations aimed at expanding the portfolio management services (PMS) industry, easing compliance requirements, consolidating regulations and removing outdated provisions.

SEBI’s reforms seek to make PMS more competitive by improving operational flexibility and simplifying compliance.

Legal opinion ‘backs’ Chandra’s renewal

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Legal opinions obtained by Tata Sons support the validity of N. Chandrasekaran’s reappointment as chairman for a third five-year term, saying the provision in the company’s Articles of Association (AoA) that requires a Selection Committee applies to the appointment of a new chairman and not to the extension or reappointment of an incumbent.

While former Supreme Court judges Justice B.N. Srikrishna and Justice Uday U. Lalit opined the casting vote exercised by the chairman of the Tata Group board was valid under the company’s AoA, the September 17 board resolution giving Mr. Chandrasekaran a third term was on lines of a similar one that gave him a second term in 2022.

Justice Srikrishna said the action was consistent



Natarajan Chandrasekaran

with Article 121, while Justice Lalit said the equality of votes among directors appointed under Article 104B provided an occasion for the chairman to exercise a casting vote.

Tata Trusts, which owns about 66% of Tata Sons, challenged the September 17 board resolution giving Mr. Chandrasekaran a third term arguing that its AoA require affirmative support from a majority of Trust-nominated directors and a chairman’s casting vote cannot override that requirement.

MDSL, GSL to boost A.P. shipbuilding plan

V. Raghavendra
VIJAYAWADA

The Andhra Pradesh (A.P.) Government’s plan to develop shipbuilding clusters secured a major fillip via tie-ups with the Mumbai-based Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Ltd. (MDSL) and Goa Shipyard Ltd. (GSL).

This apart, the Kakinada gateway port area is being showcased as another potential location for setting up a shipbuilding unit.

While MDSL has signed a pact with the government for the development of the proposed mega shipbuilding cluster at Dugarajapatnam in Tirupati district earlier this week with an investment of ₹15,000 crore, the State Cabinet on September 23 cleared the setting up of a 400-acre shipbuilding facility at Machilipatnam in partnership with GSL, which committed to invest ₹8,000 crore.

DPR (detailed project report) for Dugarajapat-

The new ports being built in Andhra Pradesh will raise capacity by another 100 million tonne

nam shipbuilding cluster is under preparation and will most probably be ready by end January, A.P. Maritime Board CEO C.V. Praveen Adhithya told *The Hindu*, noting acquisition of about 2,200 acre for this project is in advanced stages.

As far as the Dugarajapatnam project is concerned, MDSL is open to partnerships with global behemoths like HD Hyundai Heavy Industries and Imabari Shipbuilding both for funding and technology deployment.

The existing ‘other than major ports’ in A.P. are handling 100 million tonne cargo/year and the new ones being built will raise the capacity by another 100 million tonne.

National Wildlife Week

SPECIAL ISSUE

Issue date: 2nd October 2026

- Why do we celebrate National Wildlife Week?
- Spot the common birds in your area.
- Conservation success stories in India.
- The connection between Maths and Nature.
- Guess the animal from the clues given.
- The wild world along India's coastline.
- Activity sheet, folklore, and children's entries.

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Eight killed in wave of Russian drone, missile strikes on Ukraine



Saudi-backed forces repel Houthi militants' push on Taiz-Aden route



'Eight sailors in *USS Lincoln* group attempted suicide on deployment'



Pakistan deploys thousands of security forces ahead of protest



MENTALLY TOUGH

When I compete, I don't know what pain is, says Roshibina



R.V. MOORTHY

Indian wushu player Naorem Roshibina Devi fought the Asian Games title decider with a taped knee and also got hit on the face. “It is just a minor injury. When I am in competition, I forget everything. I am in a different state of mind, I don’t know what pain is,” Roshibina said about the physical discomfort.

ON A ROLL

Dilpreet stars as India crushes Korea 8-2, continues its march



AHF

In-form striker Dilpreet Singh scored a hat-trick as India outclassed Korea 8-2 in a Pool A match of the Asian Games men's hockey competition in Kakamigahara on Thursday. The third consecutive win all but assured the team a place in the semifinal. Defending champion India will next play host Japan on Saturday.

GUTS AND GLORY

Iran's Zarei overcomes wartime adversity, takes home two medals



JONATHAN SELVARAJ

Iranian rower Kimia Zarei overcame wartime disruptions back home in Hamadan to shine at the Asian Games. Zarei and Zeinab Norouzi won gold in women's lightweight double sculls and silver in double sculls. Zarei was forced to train in her room on an ergometer — rowing 20km daily amid the danger of active bombings.

STUNNING PERFORMANCE

Covid no problem for Japanese Ohashi as he breaks World record



AP

Japan's Shin Ohashi shrugged off a bout of Covid to smash the men's 200m breaststroke World record in a time of 2:04.83s at the Asian Games on Thursday. The 17-year-old won his second gold of the Games despite running a temperature of about 39 degrees just days before the competition began.

Persistence and drama on display as mixed relay team, Seema win medals

The 4x400m quartet of Vishal, Poovamma, Manu and Vithya earns silver while Seema, competing in her maiden Asiad, bags bronze in 10,000m

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Thirty minutes of persistence on the track followed by three of absolute drama saw day one of track and field competition end with a bronze and silver for India as the country opened its athletics medal tally here on Thursday.

The 4x400m mixed relay team rode on tactical personnel changes, impressive lead-off and anchor legs and a stroke of luck to finish in 3:14.46, earning silver in the final event of the day at the Paloma Mizuho stadium.

Ending a drought

Minutes before, Seema had ended a 16-year drought in 10,000m, willing herself past the line in 32:50.05 to come third.

The Indian quartet of Vishal T.K. — India's only sub-45 second quartermiler — M.R. Poovamma, Manu T.S. and Vithya Ramraj played their roles to per-



Keeping the flag flying: The relay team and Seema brought cheer to the India camp with podium finishes. R.V. MOORTHY

fection. Vishal ran with blistering pace before Poovamma and Manu ensured the team did not fall too far behind.

Vithya, the only surviving member from the team that won silver in 2023, kicked in an extra gear, edging past Vietnam by a mere 0.08 seconds.

Interestingly, India was

second in its heat in the morning, clocking 3:16.23, but replaced Jay Kumar and Kiran with Vishal and Vithya for the final.

The UAE, which had led for a large part of the race, fumbled towards the end, Mariam Kareem dropping the baton just before the final lap. She did try to retrieve it and complete but

the team was disqualified by the officials. Bahrain, led by the indefatigable Salwa Eid Naser, retained top spot with a new Games record of 3:12.87.

Seema, meanwhile, became only the third Indian woman to medal in 10,000m at the Asian Games, after Preeja Sreedharan and Kavita



Raut's historic gold-silver double back in 2010.

The 25-year-old, competing in her first Asiad, was impressive as much in her endurance to keep pace with the lead group as her race intelligence.

“At one point, I thought I could go for the win, but I could not push as hard as the others did. But now I

have begun understanding the tactics and race strategy. I will use my learning from here in 5000m,” she added.

Triple jumper Asha Ilango suffered a heartbreak, coming fourth despite a best of 13.83m — it was the same as Li Yi of China but the Indian missed out on countback.

Bronze for Satnam and Salman

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

At the end of the men's double sculls event at the 2026 Asian Games, Salman Khan had his burly hand held up by a volunteer as he navigated the short, 10-foot ramp out of the water on trembling legs.

Satnam Singh couldn't even do that.

They completed the race in 6:13.25s, just under three seconds behind second-placed Uzbekistan pair of Mekhrojbek Mamatkulov and Pavel Sorin. China's Yi Xudi, Nie Yide (6:09.77) won the gold.

Even as he lay on his back, Satnam cried out: “Gold chala gaya (we lost the gold).”

As uncharitable as they were to themselves, the two had still made history.



Gritty display: Salman and Satnam became the first Indian duo to land a medal in men's double sculls. PTI

Not only were they the first Indian duo to achieve a podium finish in this event in the Games history, they were also the only Indian rowers to win a medal in Nagoya.

It's almost a miracle that they did.

They were meant to take part in the men's quadruple sculls, considered the marquee event.

Then, two days before the start of their competition, the rowing federation decided to split up India's settled pairings. Satnam and Salman were moved to the double sculls, an event they had never competed in together.

With next to no preparation, they took to the course on Thursday morning and delivered in style.

Anantjeet-Parinaaz duo clinches bronze medal

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The shotgun contingent saved the blushes yet again for Indian shooting on a day the pistol team drew a blank at the Aichi General Shooting Range here on Thursday, with the country still waiting for its maiden gold in the sport.

Anantjeet Singh Naruka, having missed an individual medal by the narrowest of margins on Wednesday, teamed up with Parinaaz Dhaliwal to win bronze in mixed team skeet, the country's first-ever in the event at the Asian Games. The men's 10m air pistol squad, however, disappointed with all three not making the final and also failing to bag a team medal. India had won the team gold in the previous edition.

Kamaljeet, Aakash Bhardwaj and Kedarling Uchaganve stumbled while the trio stood fourth. Kamaljeet came the closest, finishing ninth with 580 points, just one off the final qualification spot. Having started well and scored a perfect 100 in his third series, Kamaljeet had poor rounds of 94 and 93 that affected his chances of advancing.

Bhardwaj shot 579 to come 11th. Uchaganve had a forgettable outing, finishing 35th with a total of 568.



Bright spot: Anantjeet and Parinaaz shone on an otherwise disappointing day for India at the shooting range. PTI

The combined score of 1727 was not enough to go past Japan: Uchaganve's last series of 92 allowed the hosts to jump to third and complete the podium with 1730 points.

Anantjeet and Parinaaz, meanwhile, started slow in qualification with a 44 in the opening round before scoring 47 each in the next two to make the final with 138 points, one point ahead of Kuwait. The final saw a close battle before India and Korea shot identical 44 points, the Koreans edging ahead by virtue of their higher finish in the

qualifying phase.

“We had a difficult start: both of us didn't shoot well in the first round but we told each other that we can still get it. We wanted to fight till the last target and that's what we did,” Anantjeet said. “We both are aggressive and rhythmic shooters, so it just works quite well. He is shooting ahead of me, so I see that and it gives me that recall,” Parinaaz said.

The pistol squad had its first victim with Kamaljeet replacing Uchaganve in the mixed team event to partner Suruchi Phogat.

INDIANS IN ACTION TODAY

A look at some Indian performances on Thursday:

Athletics: Women's 10,000m final: Seema (bronze); Women's triple jump final: Asha (fourth), Niharika (10th); 4x400m mixed relay: Silver; Men's 100m heats: Animesh (third in heat 1) and Gurindervir (second in heat 4), both qualified for the semifinals.

Boxing: Round-of-16: Men: 70kg: Sumit lost to Al-Sarray (Iraq); Women: 51kg: Sakshi lost to Balkibekova (Kaz); 65kg: Parveen w/o Nozimova (Tjk).

Fencing: Table-of-16: Women's sabre individual: Bhavani Devi lost to Xueyi (Chn) 5-15; Shreya lost to Jeon (Kor) 6-15.

Gymnastics: Women's vault

THE INDIA SHOW

final: Pranati (sixth).

Hockey: Men (Pool A): bt South Korea 8-2.

Kabaddi: Men (Group A): bt Taiwan 37-21; Women (Group A): bt Japan 50-25.

Rowing: Final: Men: Double sculls: Satnam & Salman (bronze); Single sculls: Balraj (fourth); Lightweight double sculls: Rohit & Ujjwal (fourth).

Shooting: Skeet mixed team final: Parinaaz & Anantjeet (bronze); 10m air pistol men individual qualification: Kamaljeet (ninth), Aakash (11th) and Kedarling (35th), all DNQ for final; Team final: Fourth.

Squash: Round-of-16: Men: Abhay bt Laksiri (SL) 3-0; Veer bt

Sanjay (Mas) 3-2; Women: Tanvi bt Yhann (Sgp) 3-1; Anahat bt Lynn (Sgp) 3-0; Mixed doubles: Velavan & Joshna bt Suraj & Shameena 2-0.

Swimming: Men: 800m freestyle final: Aryan (11th overall); 50m butterfly: Benedicton (joint 12th overall), DNQ for final; 4x100m freestyle relay: 12th overall, DNQ for final.

Table tennis: Men (round 1): Manush bt Wong (Mas) 4-0; Women's doubles (round 2): Yashaswini & Diya bt Setayesh & Mahshid (Iri) 3-0; Sreeja & Syndrela bt Bolor-Erdene & Burenjargal (Mgl) 3-0.

Wushu: Women's sanda 60kg final: Roshibina lost to Zhang (Chn).

Kamaljeet, Aakash Bhardwaj and Kedarling Uchaganve stumbled while the trio stood fourth. Kamaljeet came the closest, finishing ninth with 580 points, just one off the final qualification spot. Having started well and scored a perfect 100 in his third series, Kamaljeet had poor rounds of 94 and 93 that affected his chances of advancing.

Bhardwaj shot 579 to come 11th. Uchaganve had a forgettable outing, finishing 35th with a total of 568.

Athletics: Women's heptathlon (Anamika, Pooja), 6.30 a.m. onwards; Women's shot put final (Manpreet, Krishna), 3.35 p.m.; Women's pole vault final (Sindhushree, Baranica), 4.30 p.m.; Women's 400m heats (Kiran, Prachi), 5.50 p.m.; Men's 100m semifinals (Gurindervir, Animesh), 4 p.m.; final, 6.50 p.m.; Men's 10,000m final (Gulveer), 5 p.m.; Men's hammer throw final (Damneet, Praveen), 5.10 p.m.; Men's 400m heats (Vishal), 6.20 p.m.

Badminton: First round: Mixed doubles: Dhruv & Tanisha vs. Nibal & Aminath (Mdv), 6.10 a.m.; Men's doubles (not before 4 p.m.); Satwiksairaj & Chirag vs. Pakkapon & Peeratchai (Tha); Hariharan & Arjun vs. Fajar & Shohibul (Ina).

Boxing: Round-of-16: Men's 60kg: Sachin vs. Jajeh (Jor), 10.15 a.m.; Women's 54kg: Preeti vs. Mi (PRK), 2.15 p.m.

Fencing: Table-of-16: Men's foil team: vs. Hong Kong, 6 a.m.; Women's epee team: vs. Uzbekistan, 7 a.m.

Hockey: Women (Pool B): vs. Japan, 7.30 a.m.

Kamaljeet), 6.15 a.m.; final, 8.30 a.m.; 50m rifle 3P men individual qualification and team final (Aishwary Pratap, Rudranksh, Niraj), 7.15 a.m.; individual final, 10.30 a.m.

Squash: Quarterfinals: Mixed doubles: Velavan & Joshna vs. Pelino & Aribado (Phi), 7 a.m.; Men: Abhay vs. Tsukue (Jpn), 9.15 a.m.; Veer vs. Irfan (Pak), 10.45 a.m.; Women: Anahat vs. Tanvi, 10 a.m.

Swimming: Heats (from 6.30 a.m.): Men: 50m breaststroke (Danush); 200m backstroke (Rishabh, Utkarsh); 400m freestyle (Dhakshan, Aneesh); 200m butterfly (Sajan); finals (from 1.30 p.m.).

Table tennis: Mixed doubles (quarterfinals): Manush & Diya vs. Ting & Kem (Hkg) and Harmeet & Yashaswini vs. Lin & Kuai (Chn), both at 6.30 a.m.; Men's doubles: Round 2: Harmeet & Sathivan vs. Affan & Negara (Ina), 7.30 a.m.; Manav & Manush vs. Tomokazu & Hiroto (Jpn), 8.15 a.m.; Women: Round 2: Yashaswini vs. Zaza (Syr), 9 a.m.; Sreeja vs. Gyong (PRK), 9.45 a.m.; Men: Round 2: Manav vs. Ryong (PRK), 10.30 a.m.; Manush vs. Faraji (Iri), 11.15 a.m.; Women's doubles: Round 3: Sreeja & Syndrela vs. Kuai & Wang (Chn), noon; Yashaswini & Diya vs. Shuhan & Yi (Chn), 12.45 p.m.

Weightlifting: Women's 61kg final (Nirupama), 1.30 p.m.

Agarkar's roller-coaster ride

When the former pacer was named the chairman of selectors in July 2023, there was a sense of great optimism and feel-good; his tenure, however, was a chequered one with highs in the white-ball format and lows in the Tests



AFF

R. Kaushik

From all indications, BCCI senior chief selector Ajit Agarkar has chaired his last selection committee meeting. A little over a week back, the Agarkar-led panel picked the national squads to do duty against West Indies in three One-Day Internationals and five Twenty20 Internationals, apart from naming the Rest of India side to take on Ranji Trophy champions Jammu & Kashmir in the Irani Cup.

Among those named in the ODI squad was Rohit Sharma, the former captain whose future has been needlessly put under the microscope over the last 12 months. It is widely perceived that Rohit has inadvertently become the primary reason for Agarkar choosing, as is being touted, not to seek an extension to his term as chairman of selectors when his tenure ends early next week.

Good rapport

When Agarkar was named the chairman in July 2023, there was a sense of great optimism and feel-good. He had played alongside Rohit, by then firmly entrenched as the all-format skipper, as well as head coach Rahul Dravid. He shared a good rapport with the two men that formed the core leadership group, and it was widely anticipated that this troika would work in tandem to push Indian cricket further ahead on the path to dominance.

The honeymoon period lasted for a fair while, it can't be disputed. Under Rohit, India charged through to the final of the home 50-over World Cup in 2023 before coming a cropper in the title round against Australia, then mounted a flawless, unbeaten campaign in the Americas as they won a second T20 World Cup crown in Bridgetown in June 2024. In some ways, that victory was to prove a decisive moment in Indian cricket, and not necessarily for the reasons one might consider organic or positive.

Dravid's tenure as head coach ended with India's defeat to Australia, before he was persuaded by the Board of Control for Cricket in India and, more decisively, by a phone call from Rohit, to stay on till the end of the T20 World Cup. That proved to be a masterstroke; Rohit and Dravid realised there was unfinished business to address, and while the T20 World Cup might not hold the same aura as its more established white-ball counterpart, it was immensely satisfying for the two driven men that, finally, they had worthwhile silverware to show for their hegemony, hard work and entertaining, aggressive brand of cricket.

As Dravid walked away into the sunset and V.V.S. Laxman expressed his inability to take over as head coach, the BCCI's hunt for a successor to the Bengalurean ended with Gautam Gambhir, the pugnacious former opener with a feisty, confrontational streak. Gambhir came with his own set of ideas. Unstated but perhaps somewhere near the top of that list was a desire to put together a new, young Test team that didn't have a place at some stage in the not-too-distant future for Rohit, his predecessor Virat Kohli and off-spinning giant R. Ashwin.

The first seeds of discontent were sowed in Gambhir's second series in



Agarkar and Laxman... communication lines blurred? FILE PHOTO: N. SRIDHARAN N. SRIDHARAN

charge, at home against New Zealand in October-November 2024. India were crushed 0-3, their first home series loss in more than a decade, and the finger-pointing began almost immediately.

Within months of that debacle, the celebrated trio had played its last Tests at different times on the subsequent tour of Australia, which India lost 1-3. Rohit missed the first game, victory in Perth, as he was away on paternity leave, and when he rejoined the team, his form deserted him summarily. Ashwin retired midway through the series, Rohit dropped himself for the final game in Sydney owing to poor form and Kohli's tour unravelling dramatically after an unbeaten second-innings hundred in Perth as he unerringly found the slip cordon time after time.

Thorny transition

Rohit and Kohli announced their retirement from Test cricket within a week of each other in May 2025. By this time, Gambhir and Agarkar had already embarked on the tricky path to transition. To lose three giants in one fell swoop isn't easy to recover from. Agarkar's panel had its work cut out but it showed gumption and a propensity to go with its gut by naming Shubman Gill as the Test captain.

Gill's first assignment was an away tour of England, where he showed sensational form and reasonably promising tactical awareness in securing a fabulous 2-2 stalemate. The captain led from the front with four hundreds, including a monumental 269 in Birmingham, on his way to 754 dazzling runs and eked out fantastic returns from Mohammed Siraj and Prasidh Krishna as both of India's victories came when Jasprit Bumrah was rested to manage his workload.

Agarkar's panel bared its intentions when it brought Gill back into the T20I setup -- as the vice-captain to Suryakumar Yadav, no less -- and thrust him into the hot-seat in the ODI format too last October. Between the Australia Test series and IPL 2025, during the course of which Rohit and Kohli announced their Test retirements, India had won five matches on the trot to storm to the Champions' Trophy title in the desert sands of Dubai in March.

Rohit had masterminded that charge with aplomb, using his bat as a scything weapon and leading with characteristic nous and acumen, but in a clear indication that he was on borrowed time, Agarkar and his men believed a change in leadership was imperative with the next 50-over World Cup two years away.

Steadfast, dignified silence

From that point, Rohit has been a marked man, his every move dissected, his every ODI series touted as his international swansong. All of a sudden, from being the most important man in Indian cricket, he was put in a difficult place, almost having to 'prove' himself time after time. To his credit, the Mumbaier has maintained a steadfast, dignified silence -- much like he did when he was summarily divested of the Mumbai Indians captaincy a couple of years back even though he had led the franchise to five titles -- and allowed his bat to do the talking.

The last straw, the consensus is, in the Agarkar vs. Rohit saga -- a saga unfolding in social media and on the internet and in reams of newsprint -- came in England in July. Ostensibly, Rohit had been asked to announce his retirement at the end of the three-match series, after the final game at Lord's. In the lead-up to the last ODI, epitaphs were being written, cryptic posts appeared on social media platforms and it was more or less accepted that Rohit wouldn't play for the country again, until, in an unprecedented move, BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia voluntarily declared that Lord's would not be Rohit's swansong.

Clearly, that hasn't gone down well with Agarkar, and understandably so. Selection matters are the prerogative of the selectors, specifically appointed for that sole purpose. If the BCCI wanted Rohit to continue, the secretary or the office-bearers could have had a word in private with Agarkar to express their stance. The public declaration, without provocation, raised Agarkar's hackles and his relationship with the BCCI, it is presumed, soured from that point in mid-July onwards.

Notwithstanding the unseemly haste in trying to get rid of one of the greatest white-ball practitioners of all time,

Agarkar had reason to feel miffed, if not downright insulted. But he didn't cover himself in glory by not attending the review meeting called by the BCCI in Mumbai at the beginning of this month. By now, it was evident that things had reached a point of no-return, and even though Saikia made a spirited defence of the Agarkar no-show by citing personal reasons, no one had any doubts that the die had been cast.

If Agarkar does bow out, his report card will be a mixed bag. During his 38-month tenure, India won two T20 World Cups, two Asia Cups (one each in the 50- and the 20-over formats) and made it to the final of the 50-over World Cup at home. But their Test record has been abysmal -- home series routs by New Zealand and South Africa (2-0 last November), and an away series loss to Australia in 2024-25 (1-3) completely cancel out all else, including a 1-0 victory in Sri Lanka last month.

Left-field decision

India have stuttered and stumbled in the transition phase, especially when it comes to bowling, and there has been a certain ambivalence in white-ball selection. The return of Shreyas Iyer to the T20I ecosystem after three years, in the role of captain, is as much of a left-field decision as the hasty call-up and dumping of Gill from the same version last year. From the days when Indian squads looked settled and were fuelled by consistency in selection, there is a sense of insecurity and of nervously looking over one's shoulder, which is fair from the ideal scenario in which anyone can give off their best.

There have been reports of a breakdown in communication between Agarkar and Laxman, the head of the Centre of Excellence, especially when it comes to picking India 'A' squads. The CoE has chalked out long-standing pathways to prepare the next set of emerging talent for international cricket, but the selection panel has often chosen to override that pathway and thrust established Indian Test players into the mix, ostensibly for match practice, even in familiar home conditions. It is reliably learnt that Laxman wasn't even consulted when the selectors picked the squad for the Asian Games though it was clear many months back that he would be the coach in Aichi-Nagoya. So much for transparency and openness isn't a quip without substance.

Should events unfold along expected lines, India will have a new chairman very soon. They must too, because the squads for the tour of New Zealand, beginning with the first of five T20Is in Christchurch on October 22, need to be picked; the team is expected to depart from Bengaluru on October 18. The T20Is will be followed by five ODIs, the first phase of the final leg of preparations for the World Cup, and two Tests. Whoever the new chairman is -- for now, the needle points in the direction of former India stumper Parthiv Patel, who led unfancied Gujarat to the Ranji Trophy title in January 2017 -- will first have to ensure an equanimous relationship with the two captains and the head coach to ensure that the winds of uncertainty threatening to sweep through the cricketing landscape are calmed, if not quelled, post haste.

THE GIST

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There have been reports of a breakdown in communication between Agarkar and Laxman, the head of the Centre of Excellence, especially when it comes to picking India 'A' squads

HEALTH

When cancer treatment is no longer working

Modern oncology has transformed countless lives. Yet an important gap remains. We do not prepare patients and their families for uncertainty. What happens if the treatment stops helping? How much should the patient know? When should children be told? How do we decide what matters most now?

V. Divya Sai

The hardest conversation in cancer care rarely begins with the words, “There is nothing more we can do.” It usually begins much earlier. “Should we tell him?” “Can we try one more treatment?” “Will she lose hope if she knows?” These questions are asked quietly: in hospital corridors, outside intensive care units, or after doctors have left the room. They are spoken in whispers because families are not simply making medical decisions; they are trying to protect someone they love.

As a palliative medicine physician working alongside oncology teams, I have learned that when treatment is no longer working as expected, families often find themselves facing conversations they never imagined having. The challenge is not only accepting that the disease has changed; it is learning how to talk about what comes next.

Conversations we prepare least for Modern oncology has transformed countless lives. New drugs, targeted therapies, immunotherapy and better supportive care have helped many people live longer than ever before. Yet an important gap remains.

We prepare families remarkably well for chemotherapy schedules, blood tests and scan reports. We prepare them far less for conversations about uncertainty. What happens if the treatment stops helping? How much should the patient know? When should children be told? How do we decide what matters most now?

These questions do not signal that hope has disappeared. They signal that hope is changing.

A young man I recently cared for had advanced blood cancer and was admitted to the ICU with severe pain. Over the next few days, his greatest distress was not only physical. Watching critically ill patients around him, he became convinced that he would be next. When he finally asked, “Am I going to die?” he was not asking for a statistical answer. He was asking whether someone would help him understand what was happening.

Another family kept asking whether there was “one last option.” As our conversation unfolded, it became clear that they were not asking for another medicine. They wanted enough time to gather siblings from different cities, celebrate one more birthday together, and prepare for conversations they had



Care that continues: Patients frequently sense when their condition is changing, even when nobody says it directly. Silence can sometimes create greater fear than truth because people begin imagining conversations they are not allowed to have. GETTY IMAGES

been postponing. Often, the real question is different from the one being asked aloud.

Weaving honesty and hope Many families worry that honest conversations will extinguish hope. In reality, compassionate communication does not require choosing between honesty and kindness. Patients frequently sense when their condition is changing, even when nobody says it directly. Silence can sometimes create greater fear than truth because people begin imagining conversations they are not allowed to have.

Good communication means understanding how much information a patient wishes to receive, respecting cultural and family dynamics, and revisiting discussions as situations evolve. It is rarely a single conversation. More often, it is a series of conversations built on trust. Hope also evolves. Early in illness, hope may mean cure. Later, it may mean attending a daughter’s wedding, spending time at home instead of the hospital, sleeping through the night without pain, or simply being able to share one meaningful conversation with a loved one.

One of the biggest misconceptions is

Good communication means understanding how much information a patient wishes to receive, respecting cultural and family dynamics, and revisiting discussions as situations evolve

that palliative care begins only after treatment ends.

In reality, it works alongside cancer treatment by helping patients manage pain, breathlessness, nausea, anxiety, fatigue and caregiver distress while supporting difficult decision-making. Some of the most meaningful palliative care conversations happen while patients are still receiving active treatment. Instead of asking only, “What is the next treatment?”, we also ask: “What matters most to you?”; “What are you hoping for?” and “What are you worried about?”

These questions often reveal priorities that laboratory values never can.

Here are some conversations families should not delay having with loved ones who have cancer. When facing advanced cancer, especially, these discussions are easier before a crisis occurs: Ask what the patient wants to know about their illness. Discuss goals that matter to them beyond

treatment. Talk about symptom control early rather than waiting for unbearable pain. Identify who should make decisions if the patient cannot. Ask for a palliative care consultation early-alongside oncology-not only during the final days.

These conversations are not about giving up. They are about giving families the chance to make decisions with clarity instead of panic.

There is one moment I return to often. A family once told me, after losing someone they loved, “We don’t remember every medicine that was given. We remember that she wasn’t in pain, that we were able to sit together, and that we got to say goodbye.”

Years later, families rarely remember every chemotherapy cycle. They remember whether someone explained what was happening; whether suffering was relieved; whether they felt alone. Perhaps that is the real purpose of these conversations. Not to predict the future; not to remove grief: but to ensure that even when treatment changes, care never does.

(Dr. V. Divya Sai is a palliative medicine specialist at MNJ Institute of Oncology & Regional Cancer Centre, Hyderabad. vdivyasai22@gmail.com)

THE GIST

Modern oncology has transformed countless lives. New drugs, targeted therapies, immunotherapy and better supportive care have helped many people live longer than ever before. Yet an important gap remains

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BIG SHOT



Ground zero: A child being vaccinated at a health camp setup by a mobile boat clinic in the Barballa river island in Nalbari district of Assam. Several people in Assam live on “chars”, or temporary river islands and sandbars where access to even basic healthcare can be a challenge. AFP

GERD is more than just heartburn: why it is important to understand the difference

Athira Elssa Johnson

Heartburn is commonly described as acidity and treated with antacids.

But gastro-oesophageal reflux disease (GERD) is not simply acidity. It occurs when the stomach contents repeatedly move into the oesophagus because the normal anti-reflux barrier does not function effectively.

“GERD is not simply a problem of producing too much acid,” said Vishnu Abishek Raju, senior consultant, medical gastroenterology, Apollo Hospitals, Chennai. Heartburn, therefore, is a symptom, rather than a diagnosis. Some people living with reflux have visible inflammation of the oesophagus, while others have symptoms without any visible injury. GERD is common in India. A 2021 analysis of nine Indian studies involving 20,614 people estimated its pooled prevalence at 15.6%.

How reflux occurs

The lower oesophageal sphincter acts as a valve between the oesophagus and stomach. It can undergo brief, inappropriate relaxations, allowing stomach contents to move upwards.

A hiatal hernia can weaken the anti-reflux barrier by allowing part of the stomach to move above the diaphragm. Obesity, particularly excess abdominal fat,



A burning sensation may reflect acid reflux, heightened oesophageal sensitivity or another disorder, and persistent symptoms need to be assessed. GETTY IMAGES

increases pressure within the abdomen, while delayed gastric emptying can increase the volume and pressure inside the stomach.

The oesophagus also has protective mechanisms. Saliva helps clear refluxed material, while alkaline mucus helps limit acid-related injury.

“People may have acid reflux within a stipulated period. But if that goes beyond the protective mechanisms of the body, those defensive mechanisms fail and the food pipe can get damaged, a condition called oesophagitis,” said Arul Prakash, clinical lead and senior consultant in medical gastroenterology, SRM Prime Hospital, Chennai.

The amount of reflux does not always correspond to the severity of symptoms.

“Some people have increased

sensitivity of the oesophagus, so even normal amounts of reflux can produce significant burning or chest discomfort,” Dr. Abishek Raju said. This includes reflux hypersensitivity and functional heartburn. In reflux hypersensitivity, symptoms are linked to reflux events despite normal overall reflux exposure. In functional heartburn, symptoms occur without evidence that reflux is responsible.

“These are people who may feel a burning sensation with almost anything they eat because the nerves in the food pipe are very sensitive,” Dr. Arul Prakash said. This is one reason why simply increasing acid-suppressing medicines does not necessarily resolve persistent symptoms.

A response to a proton pump

inhibitor (PPI) can support a diagnosis of GERD, but it does not prove that reflux is the cause.

When symptoms continue despite appropriately used treatment, doctors may need to investigate other causes, including oesophageal motility disorders and disorders of oesophageal sensitivity.

Endoscopy is particularly important when there are alarm symptoms such as difficulty or pain while swallowing, bleeding, unexplained weight loss, persistent vomiting or anaemia. It can detect oesophagitis, ulcers, strictures and Barrett’s oesophagus.

A normal endoscopy, however, does not exclude reflux. In such cases, 24-hour pH-impedance monitoring can measure reflux episodes, distinguish acid from non-acid reflux and assess whether symptoms occur in association with reflux.

Lifestyle measures

Weight loss can reduce reflux symptoms in people who are overweight or obese. Avoiding food for about three hours before lying down can help, particularly with night-time symptoms.

Food triggers vary. Rather than eliminating multiple foods routinely, patients should identify those that consistently worsen their symptoms.

(athira.elssa@thehindu.co.in)